DOCTORAL THESIS NO. 82

The dynamics of manufacturing reshoring: exploring decision-making content with the Eclectic Paradigm

Haihan Li



HÖGSKOLAN
I GÄVLE

Gävle University Press

Dissertation for the Degree of Doctor of Philosophy in Industrial Engineering and Management to be publicly defended on Friday 16 October 2026 at 10:00 am in 12:108, University of Gävle.

External reviewer: Dr. Hamid Moradlou, University of Warwick

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Cover illustration: Wang Tsai-Ning

Gävle University Press
ISBN 978-91-90111-11-6
ISBN 978-91-90111-12-3 (pdf)
urn:nbn:se:hig:diva-49513

Distribution:
University of Gävle
Faculty of Engineering and Sustainable Development
Department of Industrial Management, Industrial Design and Mechanical Engineering
SE-801 76 Gävle, Sweden
+46 26 64 85 00
www.hig.se

For those who struggle to make decisions,
the decision is sometimes already made,
what you seek is why.

Abstract

In recent years, firms have increasingly reconsidered where they should produce. Global manufacturing has undergone significant spatial realignment. After decades of offshoring, many companies are bringing their manufacturing activities back home, to be closer to their target markets. This movement, commonly referred to as reshoring, reflects a changing global environment shaped by uncertainty, supply chain disruptions, and shifting strategic priorities. Despite the body of research growing rapidly, existing knowledge remains fragmented and lacks a coherent understanding of reshoring decision-making.

This thesis aims to develop a contemporary, integrated, and theoretically grounded understanding of manufacturing reshoring decision-making content. It examines and presents the dynamics of reshoring. Guided by three research questions, the thesis identified key decision factors, examined their interrelationships, and analysed how their roles and relative priorities vary across decision-making stages, and over time. Methodologically, it comprises three complementary studies presented in five appended papers: a systematic literature review that establishes the conceptual foundation and refines the application of the Eclectic Paradigm (EP) in manufacturing location decision research. An interview study with industrial experts provides in-depth insight into which factors influence reshoring decision-making and how they do so in practice. A structured expert-assessment survey then systematically examines the current roles and relative priorities of these factors, differences across decision-making stages, and expected future changes.

Findings show that manufacturing reshoring decision-making is inherently dynamic across three dimensions: role dynamics (where factors may function as drivers, barriers, and enablers depending on context), stage dynamics (shifting from risk-led awareness to value-led formal assessment), and temporal dynamics (evolving factor priorities over time). Current Nordic reshoring is identified as efficiency-led but not efficiency-only, while future reshoring is expected to be associated with capability readiness. By systematically mapping decision factors to their influencing roles and structuring them through the EP, the thesis provides a coherent understanding of reshoring decision-making.

Keywords: manufacturing relocation, reshoring, decision-making, deglobalisation, decision criteria, influencing factors, driver, barrier, enabler

Sammanfattning

Under de senaste åren har företag i allt större utsträckning omprövat var de ska producera. Den globala tillverkningen har genomgått betydande geografiska förändringar. Efter årtionden av offshoring väljer många företag att flytta tillbaka tillverkning till hemlandet, bland annat för att komma närmare sina målmarknader. Denna utveckling, ofta benämnd reshoring, speglar en föränderlig global omvärld präglad av osäkerhet, störningar i försörjningskedjor och förändrade strategiska prioriteringar. Trots den snabbt växande forskningen är kunskapen fortfarande fragmenterad och saknar en sammanhållen förståelse av beslutsfattandet kring reshoring.

Avhandlingen syftar till att utveckla en samtida, integrerad och teoretiskt förankrad förståelse av innehållet i beslutsfattandet kring reshoring av tillverkning. Utifrån tre forskningsfrågor identifieras centrala beslutsfaktorer, deras inbördes samband analyseras och variationer i deras roller och relativa prioriteringar över beslutsfaser och tid undersöks. Metodologiskt omfattar avhandlingen tre kompletterande studier som presenteras i fem bifogade artiklar: en systematisk litteraturöversikt som etablerar den konceptuella grunden och förfinar tillämpningen av det eklektiska paradigmet (EP), en intervjustudie med industriella experter som undersöker vilka faktorer som påverkar reshoringbeslut och hur de gör det i praktiken, samt en strukturerad expertbedömning av faktorernas nuvarande roller, relativa prioriteringar, skillnader mellan beslutsfaser och förväntade framtida förändringar.

Resultaten visar att beslutsfattandet kring reshoring är dynamiskt och tar sig uttryck i tre dimensioner: rolldynamik, där faktorer kan växla mellan att vara drivkrafter, hinder och möjliggörare beroende på kontext; fasdynamik, där fokus skiftar från riskdriven medvetenhet till värdedriven formell bedömning; samt tidsdynamik, där faktorernas prioriteringar förändras över tid. Reshoring i Norden är främst effektivitetsdriven, men inte enbart, medan framtida reshoring förväntas vara alltmer kopplad till organisatorisk och teknisk beredskap. Genom att systematiskt koppla beslutsfaktorer till deras påverkansroller och strukturera dem med hjälp av EP ger avhandlingen en sammanhållen förståelse av beslutsfattandet kring reshoring.

Nyckelord: omlokalisering av tillverkning; reshoring; beslutsfattande; deglobalisering; beslutskriterier; påverkansfaktorer; drivkrafter; barriärer; möjliggörare

Acknowledgements

Ten years ago, shortly after turning eighteen, I made a promise to myself not to settle for the ordinary. Back then, earning a PhD seemed extraordinary to me. Today, sitting in front of my laptop, at the end of my PhD journey, I find myself rethinking what extraordinary really means.

Extraordinary people surround me at work. First came to my mind is my main supervisor, Prof. Per Hilletofth. Strict, sharp, always busy, yet always there to guide me when I need it, often with an interesting historical story. He has been like a lighthouse, guiding me in the right direction. My associate supervisor, Prof. Olli-Pekka Hilmola, has an extraordinary ability to read and analyse data critically, both in research and in daily life. He has often guided me with wise words. I have also been fortunate to meet great scholars along my academic path. Prof. Kim Hua Tan, whose lectures are always engaging and full of knowledge, showed me the joy of academia, he also made unforgettable curry and barbecues. Prof. Jia Jianhua always cheers me up and offers help, and her pie warmed a British winter. Prof. David Eriksson, who has patiently explained theories and methods to me, always with kindness, and great taste in watches. Dr. Lea Fobbe has always helped me find a way forward. Her humour and cake made the journey sweeter. They are extraordinary not only for big academic achievement, but for who they are as people. They have expanded my horizons and shaped the scholar I am becoming.

Extraordinary people surround me in life. My parents, Wu Hongrong and Li Gang, gave me life, raised me, and filled my childhood with wonderful memories. They taught me lessons no school could ever replace: be a person before becoming a scholar; and, to love unconditionally. They gave me the courage and freedom to go far, while quietly supporting me from behind. My best friend, Zhang Chuyue, is like an older sister to me. Whenever I lost myself, she reached into the darkness and pulled me back, again and again. Ann-Marie Ma taught me to stay true to myself. Karl Isak Gunnarsson taught me to find inner peace, to enjoy sunshine, raindrops, and wind on our faces, across mountains, rivers, and oceans. Wang Tsai-Ning has given me endless support and drew the best thesis cover.

I am deeply grateful to my dear friends: Dr. Ren Honghao, Hsu Hsuan-Min, Sun Cuiying, Hansa Srisurat-Leung, Lin Yuanyuan, Lin Zhen, Chen Yuting, Dr. Melis Temel, Emil Persson, and Isak Prytz Sund. You have brightened my life. Thank you for the love and laughter, they carried me further than you may ever realise, they sustained me to the end.

At this very moment, I am eating cake, drinking milk tea, and listening to one of my favourite songs, *Stockholmsvy*. Sunlight falls across my hands as I write down the names of these extraordinary people in my life. And somehow, sitting here in this very ordinary moment, my life feels extraordinary.

Ordinary is extraordinary.

Haihan Li
In my cosy apartment in Gävle, Sweden
August 2026

List of Papers

This thesis is based on the following papers, which are referred to in the text by Roman numerals.

Paper I
Li, H., Hilletofth, P., Eriksson, D., & Tate, W. (2025). Understanding the manufacturing reshoring decision-making content through the lens of the Eclectic Paradigm: a systematic literature review. *European Business Review*, 37(1), 16–48. https://doi.org/10.1108/EBR-10-2023-0300

Paper II
Li, H., Hilletofth, P., Eriksson, D., & Hilmola, O. (2025). Exploring drivers, barriers and enablers for manufacturing reshoring in the Nordic countries. *Review of International Business and Strategy*, 35(5), 583–612. https://doi.org/10.1108/RIBS-11-2024-0132

Paper III
Li, H., Hilletofth, P., Eriksson, D., & Tan, K. H. (2026). Reshoring decisions in the deglobalisation era: exploring influencing factors with the Eclectic Paradigm. *European Business Review*, 38(2), 281–308. https://doi.org/10.1108/EBR-05-2025-0152

Paper IV
Li, H. (2026). Exploring reshoring dynamics through decision-making content: A comparative index analysis in the Nordic context. *Manuscript*

Paper V
Li, H., Eriksson, D., & Hilletofth, P. (2026). Unveiling the Eclectic Paradigm in manufacturing location decisions: applications, limitations and practical guidance. *Review of International Business and Strategy*, 36(4), 541–573. https://doi.org/10.1108/RIBS-08-2025-0122

Author's contribution to the papers

Paper I

The author of this thesis was responsible for the conceptualisation of the paper, research methodology, literature review, data collection, data coding, data analysis, writing of the original draft and reviewing and editing of the paper. The co-authors supported conceptualisation, research methodology, and reviewing/editing of the manuscript.

Paper II

The author of this thesis was responsible for the conceptualisation of the paper, research methodology, literature review, data coding, data analysis, writing of the original draft and reviewing and editing of the paper. The co-authors supported conceptualisation, research methodology, data collection, and reviewing/editing of the manuscript.

Paper III

The author of this thesis was responsible for the conceptualisation of the paper, research methodology, literature review, data coding, data analysis, writing of the original draft, and reviewing and editing of the paper. The co-authors supported conceptualisation, research methodology, data collection, and reviewing/editing of the manuscript.

Paper IV

The author of this thesis was responsible for its conceptualisation, research design, assessment instrument development, data collection, data analysis, interpretation of the findings, writing of the original draft, and reviewing/editing of the paper.

Paper V

The author of this thesis was responsible for the conceptualisation of the paper, research methodology, literature review, data coding, data analysis, writing of the original draft, and reviewing and editing of the paper. The co-authors supported conceptualisation, research methodology and reviewing/editing of the manuscript.

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1. Introduction

This chapter introduces the research area of manufacturing reshoring decision-making. It begins by highlighting the growing complexity and strategic importance of manufacturing reshoring in contemporary global business environments. It then presents the key research gaps that motivate this thesis. The chapter continues by defining the research purpose and research questions, clarifying the scope and delimitations, and concludes by outlining the overall structure of the thesis.

1.1 Research background

Manufacturing location decisions are essential for firms' operations and supply chain strategies, as they strongly influence competitive positioning. In an increasingly volatile and uncertain global business environment, decisions about where to locate and whether to relocate manufacturing activities have become more dynamic. Firms must continuously reassess their current manufacturing locations in response to changing cost structures, evolving market requirements, technological developments, and geopolitical disruptions. Choices regarding where manufacturing activities are located directly affect firms' operations and production performance (Barbieri *et al.*, 2018; Fratocchi *et al.*, 2016; Hilletofth and Hilmola, 2023). Within this broader context, manufacturing reshoring has emerged as an important strategic choice, as more firms reconsider previously offshored manufacturing activities (Barbieri *et al.*, 2018).

Historically, globally dispersed production networks were primarily driven by offshoring strategies aimed at improving competitiveness through lower production costs and access to location-specific advantages (Fratocchi *et al.*, 2014). Since the 1970s, offshoring has become a widespread relocation strategy, enabled by globalisation and motivated primarily by cost reduction through access to lower labour costs and other location-specific advantages (Johansson *et al.*, 2019). As an important movement associated with globalisation, offshoring accelerated the dispersion of global production networks and the development of complex supply chains. Firms expected to enhance competitiveness and improve financial performance by locating manufacturing in low-cost environments (Canham and Hamilton, 2013; Heikkilä *et al.*, 2018a; Hilletofth *et al.*, 2019).

More recently, reshoring, defined as the relocation of previously offshored manufacturing back to the home country, has emerged as an alternative manufacturing relocation strategy that has attracted increasing scholarly and

managerial attention (Li *et al.*, 2025a; Olhager and Harfeldt-Berg, 2025; Pedroletti and Ciabuschi, 2023). This shift reflects the increasing awareness of the limitations associated with globally dispersed production networks. These limitations include reduced responsiveness to changing customer requirements, increased exposure to supply chain disruptions, and difficulties in meeting sustainability requirements (Fratocchi and Di Stefano, 2019; Gillani *et al.*, 2023; Moradlou *et al.*, 2021; Theyel and Hofmann, 2021). Major global disruptions, including the COVID-19 pandemic, Brexit, geopolitical tensions, Red Sea shipping disruptions, and the Russian invasion of Ukraine, have further highlighted vulnerabilities in global supply chains. As a result, firms have shown growing interest in reshoring and in reassessing their manufacturing locations (Barbieri *et al.*, 2020; Panwar *et al.*, 2022; Phillips *et al.*, 2022).

As reshoring has gained prominence, reshoring research has expanded. Scholarly attention has increasingly focused on how firms evaluate and select manufacturing location alternatives. Research commonly distinguishes between decision-making content (*what* is evaluated) and decision-making processes (*how* decisions are made). This thesis focuses on decision-making content, specifically the substantive factors firms assess when comparing manufacturing location alternatives.

Previous research has identified a wide range of elements that firms consider when evaluating manufacturing location alternatives, such as labour costs, logistics costs, quality performance, delivery lead times, flexibility, innovation capabilities, sustainability considerations, and customer proximity (e.g., Fratocchi *et al.*, 2016; Johansson *et al.*, 2019; Wiesmann *et al.*, 2017). These elements can be understood as part of the decision-making content and are referred to in this thesis as decision factors.

While one stream of research focuses on identifying which decision factors firms evaluate, another examines how certain factors influence reshoring decisions. In this thesis, such factors are referred to as influencing factors, meaning decision factors that play an active role in shaping decisions. Influencing factors may function as drivers, barriers, or enablers, depending on whether they trigger, impede, or facilitate reshoring initiatives (Engström *et al.*, 2018b; Li *et al.*, 2025b). Although decision factors and influencing factors are closely related, they have often been examined or discussed separately, thereby missing the opportunity to develop a deeper and more holistic understanding of decision-making content.

Manufacturing reshoring decisions are inherently complex due to the large number of potentially relevant decision factors and their interdependencies (Gray *et al.*, 2017; Hartman *et al.*, 2017). To structure and interpret this complexity, researchers have applied different analytical lenses (Fratocchi *et al.*, 2016; Johansson *et al.*, 2019; Wiesmann *et al.*, 2017). Commonly applied

theoretical lenses include the Eclectic Paradigm (EP) (Dunning, 1998), transaction cost economics (TCE; Williamson, 1975, 1985), and the resource-based view (RBV; Barney, 1991). These theories provide structured perspectives for understanding *how* firms align their manufacturing location decisions with broader strategic objectives. However, as discussed below, important gaps remain in how reshoring decision-making content is conceptualised and empirically examined.

1.2 Research motivation

Over the past decade, manufacturing reshoring has become an increasingly prominent research topic as firms reconsider their global production networks in response to changing conditions. Despite substantial growth in research, important gaps remain in understanding manufacturing reshoring decision-making content. Three main research gaps are particularly evident.

A first research gap concerns the lack of contemporary empirical insights. Within the reshoring decision-making content field, much research reflects conditions preceding major global disruptions, such as the COVID-19 pandemic, Brexit, the Russian invasion of Ukraine, and the Trump-era trade war. Drivers such as rising labour costs, quality issues, and increased demand for customisation (Gupta *et al.*, 2021; Hilletofth *et al.*, 2019; Johansson *et al.*, 2019), which were previously identified as important, may no longer be as influential. These recent global disturbances have also exposed vulnerabilities in globally dispersed production networks (Barbieri *et al.*, 2020; Choudhary *et al.*, 2023). These developments have increased concerns regarding geopolitical uncertainty and forced firms to reassess their strategies and previously established assumptions (Huq *et al.*, 2021; Moradlou *et al.*, 2021). Consequently, there is a need for updated empirical knowledge to clarify which decision factors currently shape reshoring decisions, how firms prioritise them, and how their importance evolves in dynamic environments.

A second research gap relates to the lack of a comprehensive and integrated understanding. Although numerous decision factors have been identified (Bailey and De Propris, 2014; Fratocchi *et al.*, 2016; Stentoft *et al.*, 2016), existing research has mainly examined them through a driver perspective. This narrow focus overlooks the fact that one decision factor may function as a driver, barrier, or enabler depending on context (Bettiol *et al.*, 2023; Engström *et al.*, 2018a; Sirilertsuwan *et al.*, 2019). The factors and their potential influencing roles have been treated separately (Johansson and Olhager, 2018a; Pearce, 2014; Wan *et al.*, 2019), thus missing the chance to understand how these roles interact and evolve. The relevance and influence of decision factors may also vary depending on contingent conditions, such as firm-specific, industry-specific, and country-specific conditions. This fragmentation constrains the

development of a structured and holistic understanding of manufacturing reshoring decision-making content.

A third research gap concerns the limited and inconsistent application of robust theoretical frameworks for analysing reshoring decision-making content. Strong theoretical grounding is essential for guiding analysis, systematic interpretation, and generalisable insights (Boffelli *et al.*, 2020; McIvor and Bals, 2021; Moradlou *et al.*, 2021). Although several theoretical perspectives (e.g., TCE and RBV) have been applied to understand reshoring, these perspectives tend to emphasise specific dimensions in isolation. The EP (Dunning, 1998), in contrast, offers a more integrative framework incorporating ownership (O), location (L), and internalisation (I) advantages. As such, it enables a comprehensive analysis of manufacturing reshoring decision-making. Despite its relevance, it has been applied inconsistently, often relying on simplified interpretations. Current research primarily focuses on OLI parameters while overlooking the EP's broader strategic implications (Ancarani *et al.*, 2015; Barbieri *et al.*, 2019; Ellram, 2013; Moradlou *et al.*, 2021). This limits its explanatory potential for understanding how factors interact and evolve in decision-making across reshoring contexts.

These gaps highlight the need for studies that provide contemporary empirical insight, develop a comprehensive and structured understanding of decision-making content, and apply a robust theoretical lens to analyse manufacturing reshoring decisions. Addressing these gaps is essential for advancing theoretical knowledge and for supporting firms in aligning manufacturing reshoring decisions with broader operations and supply chain strategies in an increasingly dynamic and uncertain global environment.

1.3 Research purpose and questions

In response to the identified research gaps, the purpose of this thesis is to develop a contemporary, integrated, and theoretically grounded understanding of manufacturing reshoring decision-making content. Specifically, the thesis examines which factors are central to reshoring decisions, how these factors interrelate and assume different influencing roles, and how their importance varies across decision-making stages and evolves over time. In doing so, the thesis contributes insights into how reshoring decisions unfold in dynamic environments. The EP (Dunning, 1998) is used as the theoretical lens to structure the analysis and provide a coherent foundation for understanding manufacturing reshoring decision-making content. Accordingly, three overarching research questions (RQs) were formulated:

RQ1. What are the key factors firms consider in manufacturing reshoring decision-making?

RQ2. How do these key factors interrelate and influence manufacturing reshoring decisions?
RQ3. How do shifts in decision-making content reflect the dynamic nature of manufacturing reshoring?

RQ1 seeks to identify the key factors that firms consider when evaluating whether to bring previously offshored manufacturing activities back. This question is necessary as reshoring decisions typically involve a wide range of considerations. Identifying these factors provides the foundation for understanding what constitutes the decision-making content. RQ2 explores how these factors relate to one another and how they shape reshoring decisions through different influencing roles. Understanding these interdependencies is essential for supporting informed managerial decision-making, optimising resource allocation, and ensuring that reshoring initiatives align with long-term strategic objectives. RQ3 investigates reshoring dynamics by examining how the importance of the key factors evolves both over time and across different stages of the decision-making process. The emphasis is on understanding the dynamic and context-dependent nature of reshoring decisions. Together, these three RQs provide the basis for a more integrated understanding of manufacturing reshoring decision-making content.

To address the research questions and fulfil the thesis purpose, three exploratory studies were conducted. *Study A* consisted of a literature review and resulted in two appended papers (Papers I and V). *Study B* consisted of an interview study and resulted in two appended papers (Papers II and III). Finally, *Study C* consisted of a structured expert-assessment survey and resulted in one appended paper (Paper IV). Table 1 presents how the appended papers contribute to addressing the three RQs.

Table 1 Appended papers addressing the RQs

	Paper				
Research question	I	II	III	IV	V
RQ1: What are the key factors firms consider in manufacturing reshoring decision-making?	X	X	X	X	
RQ2: How do these key factors interrelate and influence manufacturing reshoring decisions?	X	X	X	x	X
RQ3: How do shifts in decision-making content reflect the dynamic nature of manufacturing reshoring?	x	x	x	X	x

Note: "X" denotes a primary contribution to the research question, whereas "x" denotes a secondary or partial contribution.

The three studies are complementary and collectively contribute to developing a contemporary, integrated, and theoretically grounded understanding of manufacturing reshoring decision-making content. Building on insights generated

from *Study A* and *Study B*, *Study C* further examines and refines the findings by exploring reshoring dynamics across decision-making phases and over time.

1.4 Research scope and delimitations

Manufacturing reshoring decision-making content constitutes the central focus of this thesis (Figure 1). In line with prior research, manufacturing reshoring in this thesis is defined as the relocation of in-house or outsourced manufacturing activities from foreign to domestic location (Ellram, 2013; Wiesmann *et al.*, 2017). The specific scope of reshoring (e.g., factory, product, component, or production process/phase) and its extent (i.e., complete or partial reshoring) are not further distinguished, as the emphasis lies on understanding the underlying decision-making content.

To capture the reshoring dynamics, the thesis first identifies key factors constituting the decision-making content, including both decision and influencing factors. The thesis then examines how these factors interrelate and how their associated strategic advantages and relative importance vary across decision-making stages and over time.

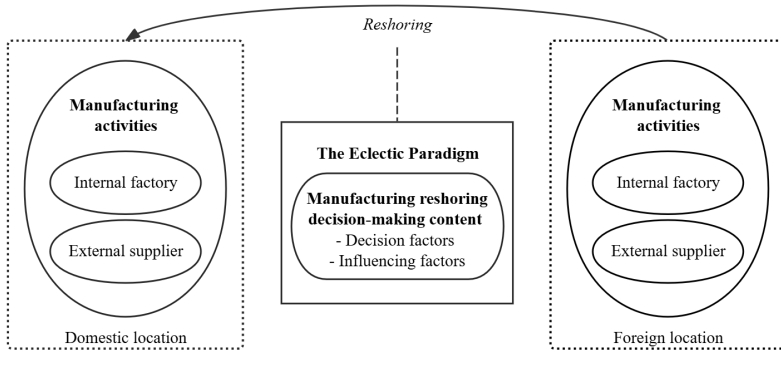


Figure 1 Research scope and delimitations

The EP (Dunning, 1998) serves as a theoretical lens. This framework is widely applied in international manufacturing research and provides a structured basis for analysing the determinants of manufacturing reshoring decisions. In this thesis, the EP is used to categorise decision factors according to four advantage-seeking categories: resource-seeking, market-seeking, efficiency-seeking, and strategic asset-seeking logics. Accordingly, the EP provides a conceptual foundation for analysing and interpreting manufacturing reshoring

decision-making content and enables a structured examination of how decision factors interact and influence reshoring decisions across different contexts.

1.5 Thesis structure

This doctoral thesis consists of six chapters and five appended research papers. The chapters are structured as follows:

Chapter 1 – Introduction: Presents the research background, outlines the research gaps, defines the research purpose and RQs, and clarifies the scope and delimitations. It concludes by providing an overview of the thesis structure.

Chapter 2 – Theoretical framework: Presents the conceptual and theoretical foundations of the thesis. It first introduces manufacturing location decisions as the broader decision context, then reviews and compares the main theoretical lenses used to analyse reshoring decision-making. It then introduces the EP as the theoretical foundation of the thesis, discusses reshoring decision-making processes, and examines reshoring decision-making content, including decision factors and influencing factors.

Chapter 3 – Methodology: Describes the methodological approach adopted in the thesis. It outlines the research philosophy, research design, approach, and strategy, and details the data collection and analysis methods used in the three studies. It also discusses research quality, ethical considerations, and methodological limitations.

Chapter 4 – Summary of appended papers: Summarises five appended papers, including their respective purpose, research backgrounds, approaches, and key findings. It also explains how each paper contributes to addressing the RQs.

Chapter 5 – Discussion: Synthesises the findings from the appended papers and discusses them in relation to the RQs.

Chapter 6 – Conclusions: Presents the overall conclusions of the thesis. It highlights the key contributions and implications. It further presents limitations and proposes avenues for future research.

2. Theoretical framework

This chapter presents concepts related to manufacturing reshoring decision-making content. It begins by positioning manufacturing location decisions as the broader decision domain and then reviews and compares the main theoretical lenses used to analyse reshoring decision-making. Next, the EP (Dunning, 1998) is selected and introduced as the theoretical foundation guiding the discussion and synthesis of knowledge related to the research questions. The chapter then discusses reshoring decision-making processes, followed by a focused examination of reshoring decision-making content and the key factors identified in prior research.

2.1 Manufacturing location decisions

Manufacturing location decisions constitute a central element of operations and supply chain strategy, as they determine where manufacturing activities are established and performed within global production networks (Boffelli and Johansson, 2020; Fratocchi *et al.*, 2014). Such decisions have long-term strategic implications affecting cost structures, operational flexibility, lead times, risk exposure, market responsiveness, and overall competitiveness (Barbieri *et al.*, 2018; Hilletofth and Hilmola, 2023; Johansson and Olhager, 2018b). These decisions are also dynamic in nature, as firms continuously adapt and reconfigure their manufacturing footprints in response to changing competitive, operational, technological, and environmental conditions (Gray *et al.*, 2017; Theyel *et al.*, 2018).

In this thesis, manufacturing location decisions are understood as an umbrella term that includes both initial location decisions and relocation decisions (Figure 2). Initial location decisions refer to establishment of new manufacturing activities in a particular location while relocation decisions refer to reconfiguration of existing manufacturing activities (Ellram, 1996; Fratocchi *et al.*, 2014; Johansson and Olhager, 2018a).

Both initial and relocation decisions involve the evaluation of location alternatives. For the initial location decision, firms can choose to establish manufacturing activities domestically or internationally. For relocation decisions, firms may choose among several alternatives. They may relocate manufacturing activities to geographically closer locations, often referred to as nearshoring; relocate back to the home country, referred to as reshoring; or relocate to a foreign location, referred to as offshoring. In some cases, firms may also further relocate activities from one foreign location to another (Hartman *et al.*,

2017; Panova and Hilletofth, 2017). These relocation alternatives differ in geographical direction and reflect firms' strategic goals and contextual conditions (Engström *et al.*, 2018a; Theyel *et al.*, 2018). Compared to initial location decisions, relocation decisions are typically more complex due to existing investments, supplier relationships, and knowledge embeddedness (Boffelli *et al.*, 2020).

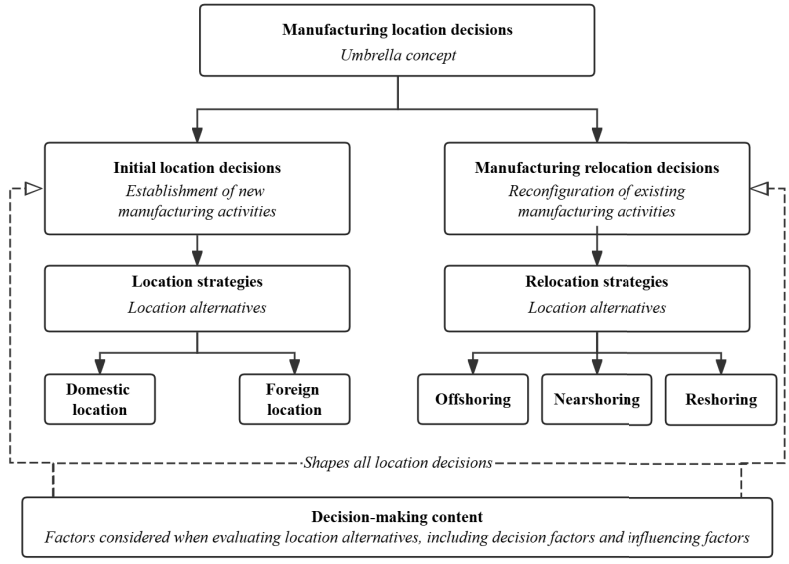


Figure 2 Conceptual structure of manufacturing location decision-making

These relocation strategies represent alternative approaches to configuring global production networks and involve trade-offs among different strategic advantages (Boffelli *et al.*, 2020; Li *et al.*, 2025b). Understanding this distinction is important for positioning reshoring within the broader manufacturing location decision-making context. Among these relocation strategies, reshoring has attracted increasing attention due to growing concerns regarding geopolitical uncertainty, sustainability, and rising offshore operational complexity. In this thesis, reshoring is not treated as an isolated phenomenon, but as one manufacturing relocation alternative within the broader context of manufacturing location decision-making. This perspective makes it possible to analyse reshoring within the broader context of manufacturing location decisions, concerning where manufacturing activities should be located, why firms reconsider existing location configurations, and how alternative locations are evaluated.

The way firms evaluate and choose among these location alternatives is shaped by decision-making content. In this thesis, decision-making content

refers to the factors considered when evaluating manufacturing location alternatives. Although relocation strategies such as offshoring and reshoring differ in geographical direction and strategic emphasis, the underlying decision-making content is fundamentally similar. Firms typically evaluate the same broad categories of factors and make trade-offs between different strategic advantages (Kinkel and Maloca, 2009; Theyel *et al.*, 2018). What differs primarily is the relative importance of these factors in various contexts. Consequently, understanding reshoring decision-making content can also contribute to broader knowledge concerning other relocation strategies.

This section introduces manufacturing location decisions as the broader decision context. Since the focus of this thesis is reshoring, the following sections narrow the discussion to reshoring decision-making.

2.2 Theories for analysing reshoring decision-making

Manufacturing reshoring is a complex phenomenon involving strategic, operational, organisational, and locational considerations. As a result, reshoring decision-making has been analysed using several different theoretical perspectives. Most common perspectives include TCE (Williamson, 1975, 1985), RBV (Barney, 1991), and the EP (Dunning, 1988, 1998). Some studies have adopted multi-theoretical approaches to capture all considerations involved in reshoring decisions (McIvor and Bals, 2021; McIvor *et al.*, 2025; Pedroletti and Ciabuschi, 2023).

One influential perspective is TCE. It explains firm decisions in terms of the comparative costs of organising transactions; specifically, it highlights coordination costs, opportunism, uncertainty, and asset specificity (Williamson, 1985). As such, TCE is useful for explaining reshoring when firms reassess the costs and risks of offshore arrangements (McIvor and Bals, 2021; McIvor *et al.*, 2025). It particularly helps explain issues in coordination, quality, hidden costs, and monitoring. But it offers a rather narrow view when analysing strategic and locational considerations involved in reshoring.

A second important perspective is the RBV. RBV shifts the focus to resources and capabilities (Barney, 1991). According to the RBV, firms may achieve competitive advantage when they possess valuable or rare resources and capabilities (Barney, 1991; McIvor *et al.*, 2025). From this perspective, reshoring may be motivated by the need to protect strategic knowledge, rebuild production competence, improve innovation, or strengthen alignment between manufacturing and core capabilities (McIvor and Bals, 2021). As such, RBV is valuable for understanding capability-related factors, but it is less suited for explaining country- and location-specific factors (Canham and Hamilton, 2013; McIvor and Bals, 2021).

Table 2 Comparison of current theories applied in reshoring research

Theories	Core focus	Application in reshoring	Limitations	Overall fit in this thesis
TCE	- Governance choice/issues - Cost-related considerations - Uncertainties - Asset specificity	- Explains hidden costs - Explains coordination issues - Helps interpret supply chain risks and governance inefficiencies	- Overly cost-oriented - Does not fully capture strategic, market, resource, and country-specific factors	- Too narrow as the primary framework
RBV	- Firm-specific resources - Capabilities - Knowledge & innovation - Competitive advantage	- Explains capability rebuilding - Explains knowledge protection - Helps interpret strategic asset and competence development	- Less suitable for systematically analysing home- and host-country conditions - Gives limited support for locational trade-offs	- Useful for capability-related explanations - Insufficient alone
EP	- International production and location choice - OLI advantages - Four advantage-seeking categories	- Integrates firm-specific, governance, and country-specific factors - Helps structure diverse reshoring decision factors coherently	- Categories may overlap - Requires careful interpretation	- Best primary lens for this thesis - Structures decision factors coherently

Compared with TCE and RBV, the EP provides a broader and more integrative perspective. It was developed to explain international production and location decisions (Dunning, 1988, 1998). Through the interaction of OLI advantages, the EP provided a more comprehensive perspective for understanding manufacturing reshoring. OLI advantages can also be further categorised into four advantage-seeking categories, which reflect firms' pursuit of resource-seeking, market-seeking, efficiency-seeking, and strategic asset-seeking objectives.

A comparison of these theories and their overall fit with this thesis is presented in Table 2. TCE and RBV offer useful but partial insight. TCE is quite strong in explaining governance difficulties, coordination costs, and hidden offshore costs. RBV is valuable for resource-, capability- and knowledge-related considerations. But these two perspectives are insufficient on their own to explain the full complexity of reshoring decisions (Li *et al.*, 2025a; Pedroletti and Ciabuschi, 2023). In contrast, the EP allows market-, resource-, efficiency-, and strategic asset-related considerations to be examined together. While the EP is less able to explain micro-level managerial behaviour, this does not weaken its suitability. The theoretical lens is applied to structure and interpret reshoring decision-making content and not to develop a behavioural theory of managerial action (Dunning, 1998; Pegoraro *et al.*, 2025). Thus, the EP is especially suitable for the thesis that aims to identify key decision factors, analyse their interrelationships, and examine how their roles and importance change. The content, development, limitations and its application in this thesis are elaborated in the next section.

2.3 The EP

This thesis is grounded in the EP (Dunning, 1998) to identify and evaluate factors shaping firms' reshoring decisions. Originally, the EP (Dunning, 1979) was developed to explain foreign direct investment and cross-border production activities, and it has been widely adopted in international business research to analyse firms' internationalisation motives (Casadei and Iammarino, 2023; Wiesmann *et al.*, 2017). The framework conceptualises location decisions through OLI parameters. Ownership advantages refer to firm-specific resources and capabilities, location advantages refer to the specific advantages of particular locations, and internalisation advantages explain why firms choose to internalise activities. Then, the framework is developed, and the OLI parameters were further distinguished into four advantage-seeking categories: resource-seeking, market-seeking, efficiency-seeking, and strategic asset-seeking. Figure 3 illustrates how the structure enables a systematic classification of factors included in the reshoring decision-making content. Besides this, manufacturing reshoring decisions are affected by the interplay between

contextual contingencies, e.g., firm-specific capabilities, locational characteristics, and country considerations (Engström *et al.*, 2018a; Wiesmann *et al.*, 2017).

Importantly, decision factors do not only align neatly with one single strategic logic. Many decision factors exhibit hybrid characteristics, meaning that the same factor may reflect resource-, market-, efficiency-, and strategic asset-seeking considerations simultaneously. In this thesis, such factors are conceptualised as hybrid-seeking factors. For example, resource cost is a resource-seeking consideration when manufacturers relocate to access low-cost resources with the best quality. It is an efficiency-seeking consideration when cost-efficient production can be achieved through lower-priced resources. Similarly, high-quality infrastructure may reflect hybrid-seeking consideration. It may attract resource-seeking manufacturers when it is essential for connecting firms to business partners. When it connects firms to key customers and ensures that services or products can be delivered, it aligns with market-seeking motives. At the same time, well-developed infrastructure can enhance coordination and communication within supply networks, which supports efficiency-seeking objectives.

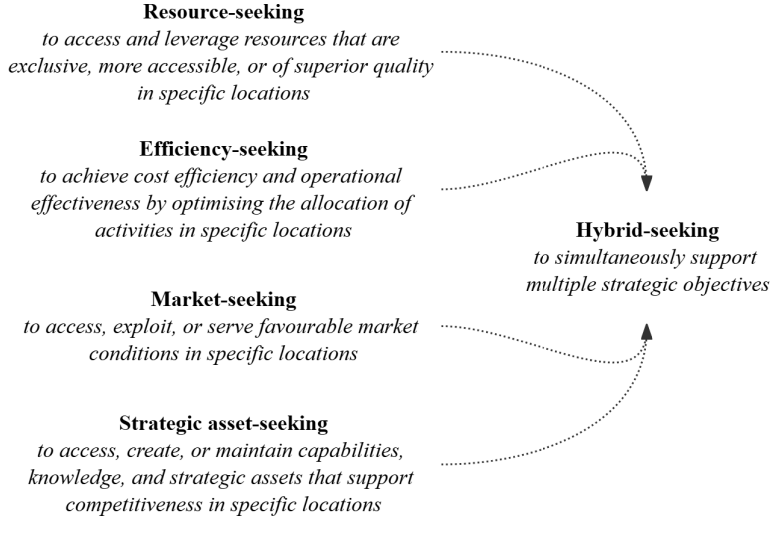


Figure 3 Advantage-seeking logics within the EP

As a conceptual framework for analysing the factors shaping international manufacturing decisions, the EP has received limited attention in reshoring decision-making research. To date, four studies have applied this theoretical perspective to identify and interpret the determinants of manufacturing reshoring decisions. The first application of the EP to reshoring decision-making

research was by Ellram (2013), who categorised factors influencing reshoring into eight key groups and then operationalised through the EP. It provides a structured foundation for later empirical research. Ancarani *et al.* (2015) later expanded the analytical scope by incorporating more recent considerations such as automation and skilled labour availability, reflecting evolving technological and capability requirements.

The EP was later extended to more complex and context-specific settings. Moradlou *et al.* (2021) applied it to examine the implications of Brexit for reshoring decisions, this research extending the range of factors considered. McIvor and Bals (2021) analysed manufacturing reshoring decision-making from a multi-theoretical perspective. While their study enriched the conceptual discussion, it did not explicitly structure the findings according to the specific categories, but treated the EP as a general concept.

While the EP provides a valuable and flexible analytical structure, it is not without limitations. One limitation is that it is not designed to explain micro-level managerial cognition, bounded rationality, or other behavioural aspects of decision-making in depth. Such perspectives are important, but this limitation is not unique to the EP, as decision-making in international production ultimately involves human judgement (Dunning, 2001). In addition, this limitation does not weaken the suitability of the framework for the thesis, since the aim here is not to explain managerial behaviour per se, but to structure and interpret the content of manufacturing reshoring decision-making. Such perspectives fall outside the primary purpose of this thesis, and this limitation therefore also opens avenues for future research.

A further challenge arises from the blurred boundaries between the paradigm's strategic motivation categories. In practice, decision factors frequently exhibit hybrid characteristics. It also faces difficulties in accommodating contingency factors related to institutional, environmental, and cultural contexts. Such influences are often highly country-, industry-, or firm-specific and cannot be meaningfully categorised without careful contextual interpretation. The application of the EP to reshoring decision-making requires sensitivity to contextual variation and an acknowledgement that decision criteria may evolve alongside changes in the global business environment.

Despite these limitations, the EP remains a highly suitable theoretical lens for this thesis. Its integrative nature allows for the structured analysis of diverse decision factors while accommodating their dynamic, overlapping, and context-dependent characteristics. Applying the EP systematically and reflexively allows this thesis to leverage its strengths, providing a theoretically grounded and contemporary understanding.

2.4 Reshoring decision-making process

Reshoring decision-making should not be understood as a single isolated decision, but as a process through which firms recognise the need to reassess the previous manufacturing configuration. Some reshoring decisions are made after firms evaluate the performance of previous offshoring arrangements (Barbieri *et al.*, 2018; Boffelli and Johansson, 2020), whereas others emerge in response to changing conditions (Fratocchi *et al.*, 2016; Joubioux and Vanpoucke, 2016). In this sense, as illustrated in Figure 4, the reshoring decision-making process begins with triggers that create awareness of problems, opportunities, or misalignment in the existing manufacturing location configuration (Boffelli and Johansson, 2020; Boffelli *et al.*, 2020). This awareness may then lead firms into a decision-making stage, where reshoring is assessed and compared with other location alternatives. Once the reshoring decision is made, firms implement the new manufacturing configuration and then enter the evaluation stage (Bals *et al.*, 2016; Zhang *et al.*, 2023). The results of evaluating reshoring performance outcomes may generate new triggers, leading to further reassessment. Accordingly, reshoring decision-making involves awareness, decision-making, and evaluation.

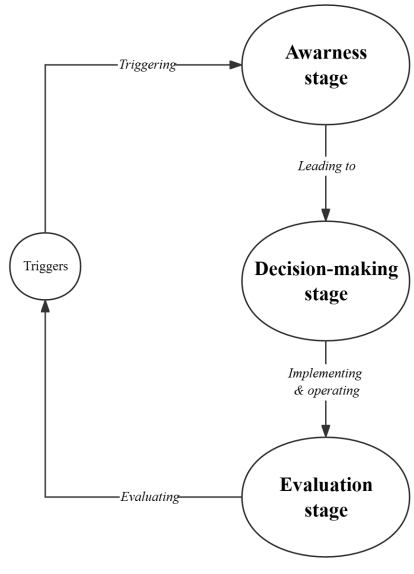


Figure 4 General process of manufacturing reshoring decision-making

Within this overall process, the decision-making stage usually includes two main steps: initial assessment and formal decision-making. As shown in Figure 5, the initial assessment step concerns the preliminary evaluation of whether

reshoring is relevant and feasible. At this stage, firms may assess the seriousness of the trigger, and the potential of relocating manufacturing back to the home country. The formal decision-making step involves a more systematic evaluation of reshoring. Figure 5 clarifies that the decision-making stage is not a single moment of choice but includes early consideration and more formal evaluation.

Viewing reshoring as a process is important because the relevance and role of decision factors may vary across different stages (Bals *et al.*, 2016; Theyel *et al.*, 2018), and it reflects reshoring dynamics. Some factors may trigger awareness of the need to reassess previous manufacturing configuration or support the initial assessment of reshoring feasibility, and others may become more important during formal decision-making, or evaluation (Engström *et al.*, 2018b). This means that reshoring decision-making should be understood by examining why firms reshore, as well as how relevant factors are interpreted during the process (Li *et al.*, 2025b; Pedroletti and Ciabuschi, 2023).

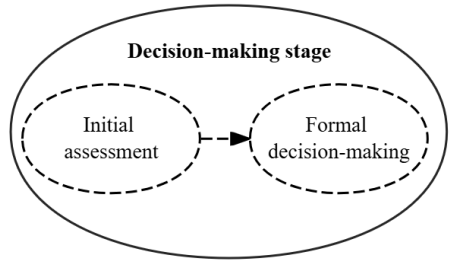


Figure 5 Structure of the decision-making stage

The relative importance of each factor included in the decision-making content may vary across reshoring stages. While the decision-making content itself may remain relatively stable, the roles and importance of individual factors may change as firms move between different stages. This concept is developed further in Section 2.5.

Although this section focuses on reshoring, the process-based logic is also relevant to other manufacturing location or relocation decisions, thus contributing to the broader concept.

2.5 Reshoring decision-making content

Manufacturing reshoring decisions are inherently complex and strategically significant, often involving numerous interrelated considerations. Making accurate and appropriate reshoring decisions therefore requires sufficient information and advanced decision support to ensure alignment with firms' overall business strategies (Hilletofth *et al.,* 2021; Wiesmann *et al.*, 2017). Decision-

making content refers to the factors considered when evaluating manufacturing location alternatives. As reshoring decisions reflect the strategic, operational, and contextual considerations of the reshoring firm, understanding their content is essential for explaining why firms make such decisions and how they are going to implement it (Hilletofth *et al.*, 2021; Wiesmann *et al.*, 2017).

Decision-making content may vary across industries and evolve over time in response to changing business environments (Gray *et al.*, 2017). Developing a robust understanding of reshoring therefore requires systematic examination of the decision-making content underpinning such reshoring choices (Wiesmann *et al.*, 2017). In this thesis, all factors considered in the decision-making can be seen as decision factors (Li *et al.*, 2025a). Within this broader set of decision factors, certain factors exert a more explicit influence on reshoring outcomes by triggering, impeding, or facilitating the decision. These factors are collectively referred to as influencing factors, i.e., drivers, barriers, and enablers (Figure 6).

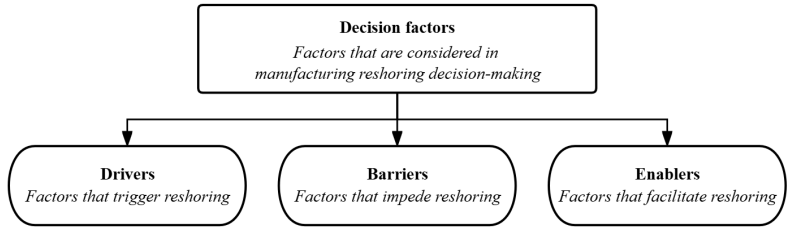


Figure 6 Manufacturing reshoring decision-making content structure

Figure 7 presents the conceptual framework guiding this thesis. Anchored in the theoretical lens of the EP, the framework structures the investigation of manufacturing reshoring decision-making content by distinguishing between decision factors and influencing factors. Decision factors represent the full set of considerations evaluated when firms assess reshoring initiatives, while influencing factors capture those decision factors that trigger, facilitate, or impede reshoring decisions.

In line with the EP, decision factors are categorised according to the strategic advantages firms seek to achieve through manufacturing reshoring decisions, namely resource-seeking, market-seeking, efficiency-seeking, and strategic asset-seeking. In addition, the framework explicitly acknowledges the presence of hybrid-seeking decision factors, reflecting the multifaceted nature of reshoring decisions, as well as capturing that a single factor simultaneously supports multiple strategic objectives. This categorisation enables a systematic and theory-consistent organisation of diverse

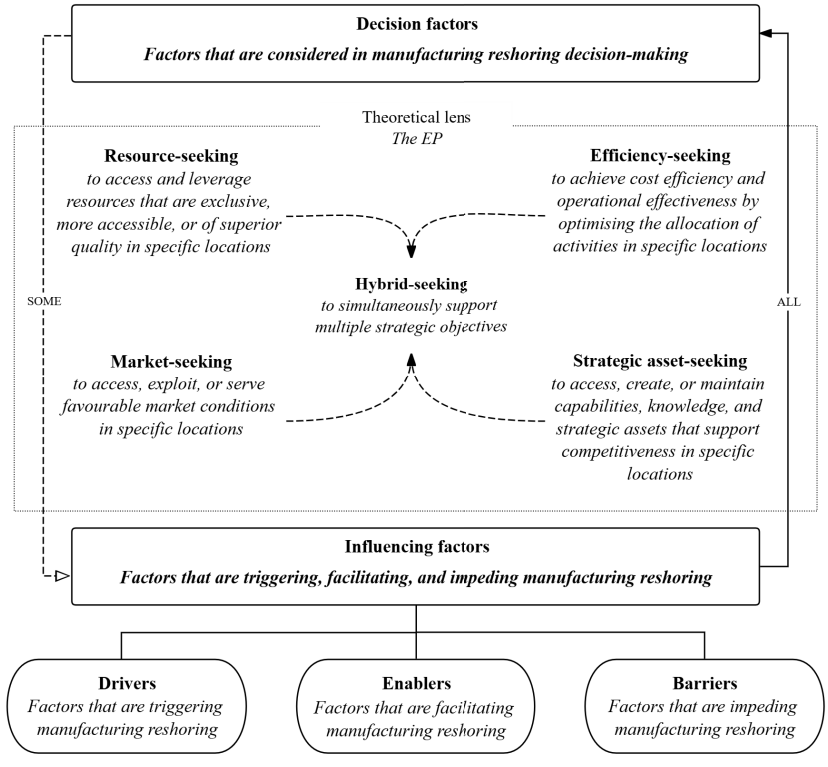


Figure 7 Conceptual framework of this thesis

decision considerations while remaining sensitive to contextual variation.

Influencing factors are conceptualised as drivers, enablers, and barriers, reflecting the roles that certain decision factors present during the decision-making process. Drivers motivate firms to initiate reshoring, barriers constrain or delay such decisions, and enablers support or facilitate implementation. The framework explicitly represents the relationship between decision factors and influencing factors through a bidirectional linkage, indicating that a given factor may function simultaneously, or shift over time, between being a general consideration and an active influence. This dynamic relationship is central to understanding the evolving nature of reshoring decision-making content. This conceptual framework integrates theoretical structure with empirical flexibility, enabling a comprehensive and dynamic analysis of manufacturing reshoring decision-making content.

The conceptual framework serves several analytical purposes in this thesis. It first supports identification and categorisation of factors constituted reshoring decision-making content, clarifies the distinction between decision factors and influencing factors. Second, as a consistent framework, it enables analysis

of how factors may differ across contexts. By incorporating hybrid-seeking logic and dynamic factor roles, the framework aligns with the thesis's focus on the evolving nature of reshoring decision-making content.

2.5.1 Decision factors

Decision factors encompass the full set of criteria that firms consider when evaluating manufacturing reshoring. In the current literature, reshoring decision factors relate to firms' motivation to access and leverage resources that are exclusive, more accessible, or of superior quality in specific locations. Such considerations typically relate to the availability and characteristics of inputs that are critical for production and operational continuity.

Scholars have proposed various approaches in categorising these factors. One approach categorises factors based on their geographical conditions, distinguishing host country and home country factors (Di Stefano *et al.*, 2024; Pedroletti and Ciabuschi, 2023; Wiesmann *et al.*, 2017). Within this perspective, home country factors shaping reshoring decisions are primarily related to firm-specific and institutional considerations, such as know-how, strategy, sustainability and social responsibility pressures (Lampón and González-Benito, 2020; Moradlou *et al.*, 2021). By contrast, host-country factors derive from conditions in the foreign production environment, including cost differentials, access to resources, and local regulations (Di Stefano *et al.*, 2024; Yang *et al.*, 2021). According to Pedroletti and Ciabuschi (2023), besides the geographical conditions in both locations, relationships between previous offshoring experience and reshoring took a big part in the decision-making. Factors such as offshoring performance, marketing factors, value chain related issues usually trigger the initiatives. Similarly, Wiesmann *et al.* (2017) and Di Stefano *et al.* (2024) also considered firm-specific characteristics within this category.

Another popular framework builds on the approach developed by Fratocchi *et al.* (2016), where factors are categorised using a two-dimensional framework. One dimension distinguishes between customer-perceived value and cost efficiency, while the other differentiates between internal or external environment. This framework has been applied and extended in subsequent studies (e.g., Bettiol *et al.*, 2023; Stentoft *et al.*, 2018).

Beyond structural classifications, some scholars emphasise contingency-based determinants. Such as firm-level determinants, industry-specific characteristics, and product-specific features, which together condition how reshoring decisions are evaluated and implemented. These contingency factors encompass the companies' business strategy and the manager's personal preferences are fundamental for decision-making. While their importance is widely acknowledged, few studies explicitly adopt a contingency-based perspective

when analysing reshoring decisions (Benstead *et al.*, 2017; Fratocchi and Di Stefano, 2019; Moradlou *et al.*, 2021; Li *et al.*, 2025a; Rasel *et al.*, 2020).

Some contingency-related factors lie outside the firm's direct control yet can substantially influence both the decision-making process and the subsequent implementation of reshoring initiatives. Examples include industry conditions, institutional constraints, and broader environmental developments, which may shape firms' strategic options and limit managerial discretion (Baraldi *et al.*, 2018; Pedroletti and Ciabuschi, 2023). This observation highlights that reshoring decisions are influenced by what firms seek to achieve and by contextual conditions that enable or constrain strategic choice, thereby underscoring the importance of distinguishing between decision factors and influencing factors.

2.5.2 Influencing factors

While decision factors constitute the broader set of considerations evaluated in manufacturing reshoring decisions, influencing factors represent those decision factors that actively shape reshoring decisions by functioning as drivers, barriers, or enablers (Bailey *et al.*, 2018; Bettiol *et al.*, 2023; Grappi *et al.*, 2020). In the existing literature, related concepts are described using different terms, as illustrated below.

Drivers, defined as the motivations behind the reshoring initiatives, have received the most attention among influencing factors. Sometimes, drivers are labelled as motivations, determinants or antecedents (Fratocchi *et al.*, 2016; Mohiuddin *et al.*, 2019; Pedroletti and Ciabuschi, 2023). While these terms reflect slightly different emphases, they share a common focus on explaining why firms initiate reshoring decisions. The term motivation emphasises firms' underlying intentions, determinants refer to variables identified as shaping reshoring decisions; and antecedents are the prior conditions or reasons that lead to reshoring decisions. Bailey and De Propris (2014) and Hilletofth *et al.* (2021) further distinguish reshoring drivers according to the direction of influence relative to firms' prior offshoring decisions, differentiating between factors that discourage offshoring (push factors) and factors that actively foster reshoring (pull factors). In this thesis, these related concepts are collectively referred to as drivers, as they all refer to factors that actively trigger or motivate manufacturing reshoring decisions.

Barriers, by contrast, are factors that hinder, delay, or discourage reshoring decisions by increasing costs, risks, or uncertainty. Limited research has investigated what holds back reshoring (e.g., barriers, pressures, risks, or challenges) in decision-making. But many studies discuss what impedes the continuation of offshoring, which may indirectly function as a driver for reshoring (Bals *et al.*, 2016; Joubioux and Vanpoucke, 2016; Moore *et al.*, 2018). Some

scholars discuss the challenges or issues during implementation (Cheng *et al.*, 2025; Grappi *et al.*, 2020; Ocicka, 2016). Scholars indicate that the understanding of barriers and potential issues associated with reshoring decisions is very important for making better-informed decisions (Joubioux and Vanpoucke, 2016; Wiesmann *et al.*, 2017).

Enablers are factors that support or facilitate reshoring by reducing constraints, increasing feasibility, or strengthening firms' implementation capacity. In current research, enablers have received considerably less attention than drivers and barriers. Very few studies examine reshoring enablers, and the concept is often overlooked. Fratocchi (2018) investigated how additive manufacturing functions as a reshoring enabler; Bettiol *et al.* (2023) examined reshoring enabling factors (i.e., enablers), including factors such as Industry 4.0 technologies, sustainability issues, and public incentives (also mentioned by Barbieri *et al.*, 2022; Fratocchi and Di Stefano, 2019). These enablers were usually treated as counterparts of barriers, but enablers may also include organisational conditions, such as internal capabilities, readiness, and cross-functional coordination.

Current research often treats drivers, barriers, and enablers separately. However, they can be seen as three perspectives of the same decision factor. This separation limits deeper interpretation of how a single factor may serve different roles. Influencing factors are not distinct from decision factors, but as a functional subset of them. A single decision factor may assume different influencing roles depending on the specific context. For instance, the same factor may act as a driver in one situation, a barrier in another, or an enabler at a later stage of the decision-making process. Reshoring decisions are shaped by *what* factors are considered and *how* these factors influence managerial judgement and strategic choice in practice.

By distinguishing influencing factors from the broader set of decision factors, a dynamic and process-oriented view of reshoring decision-making is formed. Such a distinction is essential for capturing the complexity of reshoring decisions and for understanding how contextual conditions, strategic priorities, and managerial perceptions interact to shape reshoring outcomes.

3. Methodology

This chapter presents the methodology adopted in this doctoral thesis. It outlines the research design, philosophy, approach, and strategy underpinning the study. It also discusses methodological considerations related to research quality, research ethics, as well as limitations associated with the chosen methods.

3.1 Research design

This thesis adopted a multi-study, iterative research design to explore manufacturing reshoring decision-making content and its dynamics. The overall research design combines literature-based and empirical studies. Overall, the thesis followed a progressive logic, with later studies building on earlier findings. In parallel, theoretical work was developed to strengthen the conceptual and analytical foundation of the thesis.

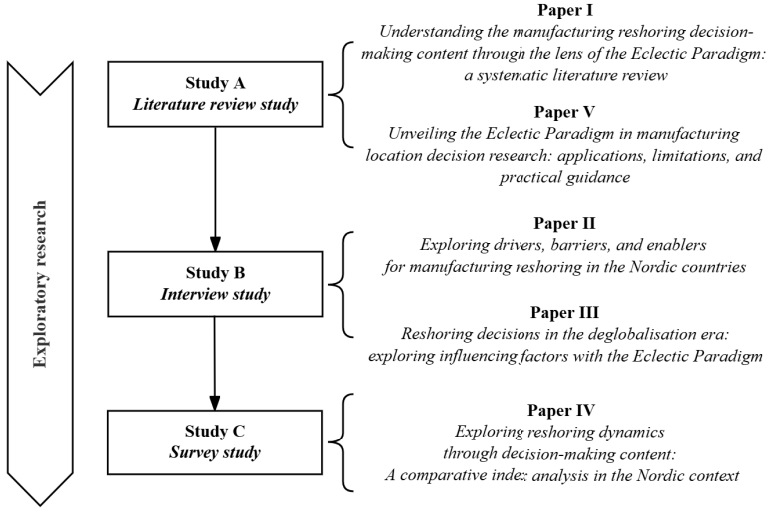


Figure 8 Overall research design

As shown in Figure 8, the overall research design consisted of three complementary exploratory studies. Each study addressed specific aspects of the RQs while contributing to the broader conceptual and empirical development of the thesis. Together, they combined qualitative and quantitative methods to ensure analytical depth and empirical breadth.

Study A established the conceptual and theoretical foundation for the thesis, and included two papers: Paper I and Paper V. It synthesised prior literature on reshoring decision-making content and clarified the use of the EP as an analytical framework. *Study A* served as an important foundation for mapping existing research landscape and refining the theoretical lens guiding the thesis. Subsequently, it supported the empirical investigation.

St*udy B* extended the conceptual insights with rich qualitative empirical evidence from industrial practice. Comprising Paper II and Paper III, it showing how factors influence reshoring decisions, and how these factors are interpreted, prioritised, and combined in practice. Together, *Study A* and *Study B* laid the foundation for understanding the factors shaping reshoring decisions, answering RQ1 and RQ2. These studies also deepened insight into the applicability of the EP for analysing manufacturing reshoring decision-making content.

Building on this foundation, *Study C*, comprising Paper IV, consolidated and extended the findings through a systematic and comparative expert assessment. Using the comprehensive framework developed in two previous studies, this study focused on the roles and relative importance of decision factors and how they differed across decision-making stages and expected to evolve over time. To strengthen analytical robustness and broaden the interpretation of the findings, *Study C* adopted a structured expert-assessment survey administered through interviews. Using comparative indices, *Study C* examined role, stage, and temporal dynamics in manufacturing reshoring decision-making content.

Across all studies, the EP served as a consistent analytical framework, supporting comparability across studies. This enabled a systematic examination and comparison of key factors in the decision-making content and its dynamics. The three studies resulted in five appended papers, which are synthesised in this thesis to develop a comprehensive understanding of manufacturing reshoring decision-making content.

3.2 Research philosophy

Research philosophy refers to the set of underlying assumptions and beliefs about the nature of knowledge and reality that guide the development of scientific inquiry (Creswell and Creswell, 2023; Saunders *et al.*, 2019). These assumptions shape how research problems are framed, how data are collected and analysed, and how findings can be interpreted. Given complexity and evolving nature of manufacturing reshoring decision-making and contextual considerations, careful reflection on research philosophy is essential to support rigorous, coherent, and meaningful knowledge development.

Research on manufacturing location decisions has a long tradition, particularly since Dunning's early work on the determinants of international

production (Dunning, 1973). Over the past decade, research specifically on reshoring has developed and expanded rapidly (D'Ambrosio and Lavoratori, 2025; Li *et al.*, 2025a, 2025b). Existing studies have examined factors that trigger or motivate reshoring (Bals *et al.*, 2016; Fratocchi *et al.*, 2016; Martínez-Mora and Merino, 2020; Moretto *et al.*, 2020), impede it (Engström *et al.*, 2018b; Sirilertsuwan *et al.*, 2019), and facilitate it (Eriksson *et al.*, 2021; Fratocchi, 2018; Sirilertsuwan *et al.*, 2019). Despite this growing body of work that has established an important knowledge base, research on reshoring decision-making content remains fragmented, and comprehensive theory-driven perspectives are still limited. As several scholars have noted, further investigation is therefore required to advance understanding in this field (Barbieri *et al.*, 2018; Moretto *et al.*, 2020). Such investigation necessitates both new empirical approaches and underlying philosophical assumptions (Eriksson and Engström, 2021). Against that background, this thesis seeks to contribute to a more coherent understanding of how manufacturing reshoring decision-making content can be structured and interpreted.

This thesis is grounded in an interpretivist research philosophy. Interpretivism assumes that social reality is not fixed and independent of human actors, but is shaped by individuals' perceptions, interpretations, and experiences (Saunders *et al.*, 2019). Manufacturing reshoring decisions are shaped by managerial judgement, strategic priorities, organisational capabilities, and external environments. These elements are not universally fixed, but are interpreted differently by relevant actors across contexts. This position is appropriate because the thesis examines how decision-makers interpret and prioritise reshoring factors across contexts and decision stages. It supports developing understanding of how the same factor may take on different roles depending on the context (Eriksson, 2015; Wiesmann *et al.*, 2017).

Interpretivist research is often linked with inductive approaches and qualitative methods (Collis and Hussey, 2014; Tracy, 2010). While the thesis is primarily interpretivist, it also incorporates structured empirical elements to enhance analytical robustness, to support systematic comparison across respondents and decision contexts. These elements were not intended to establish objective truths but complemented the qualitative insights by identifying patterns through assessment of factors. The thesis thus captures subjective views in decision-making (i.e., how factors are considered in the decision-making content based on the scenarios) and dynamics that emerge. It also strengthens the credibility of the findings with the empirical basis.

The interpretivist philosophical position also aligns with the use of the EP. As a theoretical lens, the EP is not used as a deterministic model of behaviour, but as a structured framework in organising and interpreting the findings. As such, the philosophical stance supports context-sensitive understanding, while

the EP provides theoretical structure for the analysis. Together, they enable the thesis to combine interpretive depth with conceptual consistency.

3.3 Research approach

The research approach concerns the logic through which knowledge is developed from theory and empirical material. It guides how existing theory is used, how empirical insights are generated, and how findings are interpreted (Bryman and Bell, 2015; Miles and Huberman, 1994). In this thesis, the research approach is theory-informed and exploratory, combining theoretical review with empirical investigation to develop a deeper understanding of manufacturing reshoring decision-making content.

Grounded in interpretivist philosophy, the research involves iterative movement between theory and empirical material. The EP guided the analysis, while empirical and literature-based insights informed the refinement of the analytical framework. However, the purpose is not to test hypotheses in a positivist sense, nor apply the EP mechanically. In this thesis, EP is the framework that supports exploration and interpretation of manufacturing reshoring decision-making content. Through the application and investigation of the EP, the thesis has also been able to contribute to the theory development itself.

The overall research approach is best described as inductive empirical exploration with theory-informed interpretation (Figure 9). *Study A* established the conceptual and theoretical foundation through literature-based analysis. *Study B* then generated in-depth, practice-based insights into how manufacturing reshoring decision factors were interpreted and prioritised by practitioners. Building on these findings, *Study C* systematically assessed the roles and relative priorities of the identified factors using structured evaluations from both industrial and academic experts. Across the studies, the EP provided a consistent structure for organising and interpreting the findings, and allowing context-sensitive insights to emerge. The thesis does not aim to confirm or reject the EP, but to apply, examine, and refine it as the analytical framework for understanding manufacturing reshoring decision-making content.

From a methodological perspective, the thesis combines literature-based analysis, qualitative empirical inquiry, and structured quantitative assessment. Qualitative research emphasises understanding meanings, interpretations, and contextual conditions, whereas quantitative research focuses on measuring and analysing relationships between variables (Bryman and Bell, 2015). In this thesis, these methodological elements served complementary purposes. The literature-based and qualitative components supported conceptual development and context-sensitive understanding. The structured quantitative assessment in Paper IV enabled systematic comparison of factor roles and relative priorities

across decision-making stages and time horizons. Together, they provided both analytical depth and comparability in addressing the thesis aim.

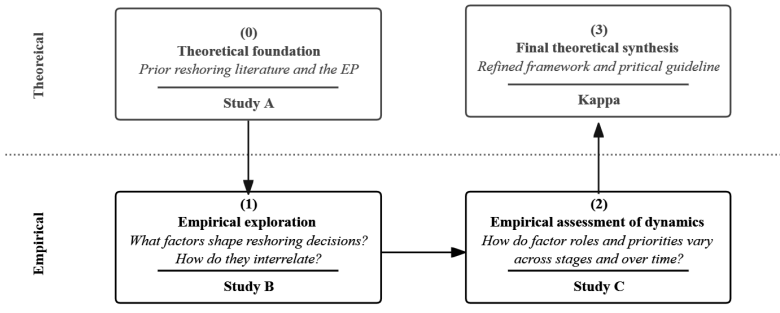


Figure 9 The research approach presented through the overall process

3.4 Research strategy

Generally, research can be conducted by carrying out experiments, observations, history analyses, surveys, and case studies. These strategies can be applied in either a quantitative or qualitative manner as well as various research objectives (Ellram, 1996; Yin, 2009). The research strategy was selected based on the RQs, as well as the need to capture the contemporary and dynamic nature of manufacturing reshoring decision-making.

This thesis aims to extend and deepen understanding of manufacturing reshoring decision-making content, with particular emphasis on the factors shaping reshoring decisions and their dynamics over time. Given the contemporary and dynamic reshoring nature, an empirical strategy grounded in real-world organisational experience is required. The research is structured as a sequential, multi-study design, with qualitative and quantitative approaches.

The research strategies are designed to support progressive exploration and theory refinement. These studies were designed to build a robust conceptual and empirical foundation for understanding reshoring decision-making content. The thesis uses three research strategies: a systematic literature review, a qualitative interview study, and a structured expert-assessment survey. Together, these strategies supported literature synthesis, in-depth empirical exploration, and structured expert assessment. The specific research strategies adopted in three studies are summarised in Table 3.

Table 3 Research strategies applied in each study

Study #	Research strategy	Data collection	Data included	Data analysis
A	Systematic literature review	Systematic database search	100 journal articles	Qualitative
B	Interview	Semi-structured interviews	16 interviews	Qualitative
C	Survey	Structured interviews	12 interviews	Quantitative

3.4.1 Study A

The research strategy chosen for *Study A* was a systematic literature review. This strategy was suitable because the thesis first required a clearer theoretical foundation. A structured synthesis of existing knowledge on manufacturing reshoring decision-making content set foundation for further empirical analysis. Systematic literature review has been widely recognised as a rigorous method for identifying relevant papers within a research topic (Durach *et al.,* 2017; Seuring and Gold, 2012).

Study A comprises two complementary papers, Paper I and Paper V. Paper I systematically mapped factors that are included in manufacturing reshoring decision-making content. Drawing on the systematic review, decision factors discussed in the literature are identified. Some of these identified factors were further analysed according to their influencing roles as drivers, barriers, or enablers in terms of how they influence reshoring decisions. Thus, the procedure establishes the linkage between decision factors and influencing factors. Based on the EP (Dunning, 1998), all decision factors were categorised into four advantage-seeking categories. Through this, Paper I also provided a theory-informed framework for the subsequent studies.

Paper V extended the theoretical foundation, it examines how the EP has been developed and applied in manufacturing reshoring decision-making research. It analysed Dunning's original and subsequent works on the EP and reviewed reshoring studies applying the EP. The findings presented its developments, limitations, and identifies inconsistencies in the research applied it. This paper also developed a practical guideline to support effective and consistent application of the EP by both researchers and practitioners.

The literature search was conducted in two databases: Scopus and Web of Science. This choice was based on broad coverage in supply chain and operations management research, ensuring access to a comprehensive and pertinent array of literature on reshoring and the EP. In addition, these databases provide access to high-quality peer-reviewed journals, providing advanced search

functions (Gusenbauer and Haddaway, 2020). The review process included defining the RQs, search strategy development, article selection, synthesis, and reporting. The systematic nature of this approach enables structured examination of the reshoring literature while supporting refinement of the EP in the context of reshoring decision-making. In doing so, *Study A* both explores reshoring decision-making content and explicates the role and applicability of the EP within this research field.

Together, Paper I and Paper V establish a robust conceptual and theoretical foundation for the thesis, supporting subsequent empirical investigation and theory development in manufacturing reshoring decision-making.

3.4.2 Study B

A qualitative interview strategy was adopted for *Study B*. The study is exploratory in nature, focusing on understanding which factors influence reshoring decisions and how these factors are interpreted, prioritised, and combined in practice. Qualitative inquiry was considered particularly suitable for capturing rich, context-sensitive insights (Yin, 2009).

Primary data were required because *Study B* aimed to capture practitioners' first-hand experiences of reshoring decision-making. Semi-structured interviews were therefore used as the main data collection method. This approach enabled in-depth exploration while allowing flexibility in exploring participants' experiences, perceptions, and interpretations in detail (Bryman and Bell, 2015; Creswell, 2014; Tracy, 2010).

Study B was conducted as part of a broader reshoring research project. Thus, the interview guide covered not only decision-making content, but also reshoring processes, assessments, and outcomes (see Appendix 1)**.** For the purposes of this thesis, only the interview material related to reshoring decision-making content was extracted, processed, and analysed. The selection of interviewees followed clearly defined criteria. First, participants were required to have direct experience of manufacturing reshoring decision-making. Second, the firms' headquarters needed to be located in the Nordic region, ensuring contextual consistency while allowing insight into a mature manufacturing environment. Focusing on individuals with first-hand reshoring experience was considered essential for capturing informed and practice-based perspectives on decision-making content. In total, 16 interviews were conducted, representing 16 manufacturing firms. The sample comprised seven managing directors and nine production managers, providing perspectives from both strategic and operational decision-making levels.

Through this strategy, *Study B* provides empirical insights into how decision factors are interpreted, prioritised, and combined in practice, thereby

complementing the literature-based findings of *Study A* and informing the subsequent empirical analysis.

3.4.3 Study C

Study C extends earlier findings by examining the roles, relative importance, and dynamics of manufacturing reshoring decision factors across decision-making stages and time horizons. A structured expert-assessment survey was adopted and administered through structured interviews. The survey instrument was developed based on the comprehensive framework established in earlier studies and includes 80 decision factors. While covering the full spectrum of decision-making content, complexity is inherent. Given the breadth and conceptual complexity, effective data collection requires respondents to have a clear and shared understanding of the survey. For this reason, structured interviews were chosen as the data collection method. This approach enabled the researcher to explain the survey design and factor definitions, supporting consistent interpretation across respondents.

Data were collected through 12 structured interviews with six industrial experts who had direct experience of manufacturing reshoring and six academic experts with expertise in manufacturing location decisions. The two groups provided complementary practice- and research-based perspectives. The primary analysis combined the assessments of all 12 experts, differences between two groups were interpreted descriptively.

Respondents first assessed the current roles (driver, barrier, or enabler) and importance (major, moderate, or minor) of each decision factor. They also identified factors considered important during the awareness stage and selected factors expected to become important future drivers, barriers, or enablers over the next one to five years. Formal decision-making stage priorities were operationalised using data of major current drivers. The stage-specific comparison was restricted to drivers.

Study C is based on 12 structured interviews. Given the expert-based and in-depth nature of the study, this sample size was considered appropriate for capturing informed and experience-based assessments. The survey instrument and analytical framework are designed to be further expanded in future research.

3.5 Research quality

Research quality was addressed across the three studies throughout the entire research process, including research design, data collection, and data analysis. The use of multiple studies and methods further strengthens research quality by enabling cross-validation and triangulation of findings (Bryman and Bell, 2015). These methodological choices were intended to strengthen validity,

reliability, transparency, and robustness. Reliability refers to the dependability and consistency of research procedures while validity concerns the extent to which the research accurately captures and represents the phenomenon under investigation (Forza, 2002; Saunders *et al.*, 2019). Although reliability and validity originate from quantitative traditions, they remain relevant for qualitative studies when interpreted appropriately (Yin, 2009; Gioia *et al.*, 2013). In qualitative research, broader quality criteria, such as rich rigour and coherence, are also relevant in evaluating interview-based analysis (Tracy, 2010).

In *Study A*, research quality was supported by an explicit and transparent review process, including clearly defined research questions, search strategies, inclusion and exclusion criteria, and analytical procedures. Construct validity is strengthened through the consistent application of the EP as an analytical lens, ensuring conceptual clarity and coherence (Yin, 2009). Internal validity is supported through systematic screening and synthesis of peer-reviewed literature, while external validity is addressed through analytical generalisation based on the quantity and quality of reviewed research.

In *Study B*, research quality was addressed through established procedures for qualitative interview research. The interview guide was grounded in prior literature and *Study A*. Internal validity and credibility are supported by probing, follow-up questions, and iterative comparison across interviews. Theoretical sampling, systematic coding, and clear documentation strengthened the trustworthiness and consistency of the qualitative analysis. External validity is strengthened by selecting interviewees with direct reshoring experience and by capturing perspectives from different organisational roles.

In *Study C*, research quality was supported through a structured expert-assessment survey administered through researcher-led interviews. The instrument based on framework established in *Study A,* supporting content validity (Forza, 2002; Malhotra and Grover, 1998). Researcher-led interviews supported consistent interpretation of concepts, factor definitions, and assessment tasks, while a standardised protocol enhanced consistency and comparability. All responses were systematically recorded and prepared. Explicit index calculations, frequency-based comparisons, and descriptive ranking strengthened analytical transparency and reliability. Including both industrial and academic experts broadened the range of informed perspectives.

Across all studies, the combination of qualitative and quantitative methods strengthens research quality by enabling methodological triangulation (Bryman and Bell, 2015; Gioia *et al.*, 2013; Tracy, 2010). By integrating multiple data sources and analytical perspectives, this thesis provides a robust and credible examination of manufacturing reshoring decision-making content. The key tactics employed to ensure research quality are summarised in Table 4.

Table 4 Research quality tactics across the applied research strategies

Study #	Validity	Reliability
A	*Construct validity* – Use of multiple academic databases (Scopus and Web of Science) providing broad coverage of relevant research – Inclusion of peer-reviewed journal articles in relevant fields – Clear conceptualisation and categorisation of decision-making content through the EP *Internal validity* – Systematic literature review procedures applied throughout data collection and analysis – Apply inclusion and exclusion criteria in data collection *External validity* – Analytical generalisation based on established literature	– Transparent documentation of search strategy and review process – Use only peer-reviewed articles – Replicable review protocol and coding procedures
B	*Construct validity* – Interview guide grounded in prior literature and *Study A* findings – Clear explanation of research purpose and concepts to respondents in data collection *Internal validity* – Pattern matching and explanation building across interviews in data analysis – Iterative comparison across interviews *External validity* – Analytical generalisation through theoretical sampling and replication logic in research design	– Use of a semi-structured interview protocol in data collection – Consistent interview procedures across respondents – Systematic coding and documentation of interview data
C	*Construct validity* – Expert-assessment instrument derived from framework developed in *Study A* – Clear operationalisation of factor roles, relative importance, and priority changes *Internal validity* – Stage-specific comparison restricted to drivers in accordance with the assessment design – Standardised explanation of concepts, factor definitions, and assessment tasks *External validity* – Inclusion of both industrial experts and scholars	– Standardised structured interview protocol across respondents – Systematic data recording and coding procedures – Transparent and replicable index calculations – Consistent treatment of non-selected and unavailable responses

3.6 Research ethics

Research ethics is an essential part of the design, conduct, and reporting of this thesis. Ethical considerations were addressed throughout the research process: research design, data collection, data storage, analysis, interpretation, and presentation (Bell and Bryman, 2007; Saunders *et al.*, 2019).

In the conceptual part of the thesis, ethical considerations were specifically related to scientific integrity and responsible scholarship. *Study A* relied on data collected from prior literature. Here, transparent search procedures, clear inclusion and exclusion criteria and proper acknowledgement of sources supported an accurate representation of earlier research (Bernard and Balog, 2025). Before the study was conducted, an audit trail of search, screening, and analytical decisions was maintained to strengthen transparency and traceability. In the process of conducting *Study A*, extra efforts have been done to avoid selective citation, misinterpretation, or overstatement of prior findings. The EP was applied to ensure consistency in analysis. These procedures were important for maintaining scientific integrity in the theoretical part of the thesis (Bell and Bryman, 2007; Israel, 2015).

Ethical considerations became especially important in the empirical part as the *Study B* and *Study C* involved direct interaction with respondents (Bell and Bryman, 2007). Semi-structured interviews were conducted with practitioners who had direct experience of manufacturing reshoring decisions. Before data collection, participants were informed about the research and how the data would be used. Participation was voluntary, and respondents were informed that they could decline to answer specific questions or withdraw from the study at any stage. All interviews were recorded with permission, and the recordings were used solely for transcription and research purposes (Bell and Bryman, 2007; Brinkmann and Kvale, 2015; Saunders *et al.*, 2019).

The same ethical principles guided *Study C*, although it used a structured expert-assessment design**.** Respondents were asked to assess 80 decision factors in terms of their roles, relative importance, and expected future priorities. Thus, clear explanation and consistent interpretation were particularly important. Before each interview, the author explained the purpose, main concepts, and the structure. During the interviews, respondents were encouraged to ask for clarification whenever necessary. By doing this, the risk of misunderstanding is reduced, and consistency is ensured. Participation was voluntary, consent was obtained prior to data collection, and respondents were informed of their right to withdraw.

Confidentiality and anonymisation were treated as central ethical principles across the empirical studies. During the data collection, information collected may involve sensitive business information, thus, interviewees and organisations were anonymised where necessary. After the data collection, identifying

details (e.g., specific individuals or firms) were removed or generalised in the reporting of findings. All empirical first-hand data were stored securely and used only for research purposes. Access to raw data was restricted to the researcher and, where relevant, supervisory support within the research process (Bell and Bryman, 2007; Saunders *et al.*, 2019; Israel, 2015).

In the data process and analysis, ethical responsibility extends to the researcher. The thesis adopted a reflexive and systematic approach throughout the research process, using the EP as the lens. In the theoretical parts, interpretations were grounded in empirical material and prior literature (Bernard and Balog, 2025) to understand and interpret how the same factor could function as a driver, barrier, or enabler in different contexts consistently. In the empirical part, the transcript, coding, categorisation, and interpretation were carefully reviewed, compared, and analysed. Finally, ethical considerations also applied to the reporting and publication of research. Authorship was determined based on contribution. Journals were selected based on their relevance and quality. These ethical considerations supported the integrity, credibility, and trustworthiness of the thesis (Israel, 2015).

4. Summary of appended papers

This chapter summarises five papers appended to this thesis. Each paper is briefly presented its purpose, especially in relation to the thesis in the research background, main findings, and key contributions. The summary highlights how the individual papers collectively contribute to a comprehensive understanding of manufacturing reshoring decision-making content and its dynamics.

4.1 Paper I: Understanding the manufacturing reshoring decision-making content through the lens of the Eclectic Paradigm: a systematic literature review

4.1.1 Research background

Manufacturing reshoring has attracted growing attention over the past decade. The trend reflecting firms' increasing concerns of global disruptions, geopolitical uncertainties, and rising sustainability pressure (Barbieri *et al.*, 2018; Wiesmann *et al.*, 2017). The body of reshoring research has expanded rapidly in the past decade but is still in its infancy. Studies about reshoring decision-making remain fragmented and often lack a consistent theoretical foundation (Barbieri *et al.*, 2019; Moradlou *et al.*, 2021). Prior research examines reshoring decision-making more from the singular factor's perspective, e.g., how cost, labour, risk, or market proximity influence the reshoring decisions. In reshoring literature, scholars refer factors considered in the decision-making differently. Some analysing based on factors level, some got more in-depth, from the role these factors served, e.g., drivers, barriers, and enablers (usually refers as enabling factors). These two perspectives are also frequently analysed separately, limiting the development of a holistic understanding of reshoring decision-making content.

Several scholars also highlight the complex, context-dependent, and multidimensional nature of reshoring decisions, and calls for theory-driven studies that can better capture this complexity (Boffelli *et al.*, 2020; McIvor and Bals, 2021). To gain in-depth understanding, it is important to explore knowledge in a systematic or structured way, and this can be achieved by using an overarching analytical framework.

The EP has extensively been applied in international manufacturing and foreign direct investment research. While it offers a well-established structure for analysing manufacturing location decisions, it has only been limited applied in reshoring studies (e.g., Ellram, 2013; Ancarani *et al.*, 2015; Moradlou *et al.*,

2021). According to the strategic advantages that companies seek through reshoring, factors can be categorised into resource-seeking, market-seeking, efficiency-seeking, and strategic asset-seeking advantages (Dunning, 1988, 1998). Given its explanatory power and flexibility, scholars have suggested that the EP has strong potential to advance the theoretical structuring of reshoring decision-making content.

4.1.2 Findings

Factors within the reshoring decision-making content can be distinguished between decision factors (*i.e.* factors considered when making location decisions) and influencing factors (*i.e.* drivers, barriers, and enablers of reshoring). Figure 10 presents how decision-making content can be analysed and understood, the EP as the overarching analytical framework for the decision-making content. In total, 80 decision factors were identified from the reviewed literature. Based on how these factors are applied or conceptualised in the original studies, they were further categorised into resource-seeking, market-seeking, efficiency-seeking, and strategic asset-seeking. Paper I discovered that some of the factors are classified as hybrid-seeking, meaning that a single factor may simultaneously support multiple strategic objectives. The findings show efficiency-seeking considerations dominate the reshoring decisions, reflecting firms' emphasis on cost efficiency, productivity, and flexibility when considering bringing manufacturing back.

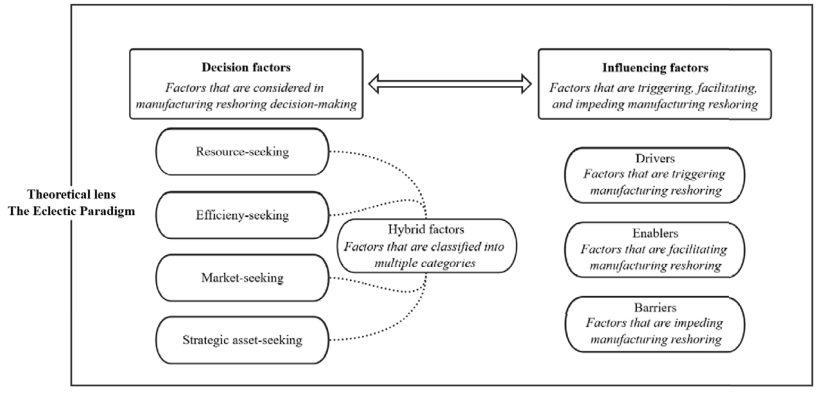


Figure 10 Conceptual framework EP with decision and influencing factors

In addition, some of the decision factors were further defined as influencing factors, i.e., drivers, barriers, or enablers. Drivers are influencing factors that trigger firms to initiate or seriously consider reshoring by creating strategic incentives or perceived opportunities. Barriers, in contrast, are influencing

factors that impede or constrain reshoring by limiting the feasibility of it. Enablers refer to influencing factors that facilitate reshoring by reducing challenges and supporting readiness.

The findings reveal that the same factor may act as a driver in one context, a barrier in another, or an enabler during implementation. Reshoring dynamics can be understood along two dimensions by evaluating the decision-making content. To assess decision factors effectively, each factor should be examined from both dimensions, namely, decision and influence (Table 5).

Table 5 Matrix of how decision factors should be understood

[Decision factor]	Driver	Barrier	Enabler
Resource-seeking	+/-/0	+/-/0	+/-/0
Market-seeking	+/-/0	+/-/0	+/-/0
Efficiency-seeking	+/-/0	+/-/0	+/-/0
Strategic asset-seeking	+/-/0	+/-/0	+/-/0

4.1.3 Contribution to the thesis

Paper I provides the theoretical foundation and conceptual backbone of this thesis. It is the first study to systematically examine the value and practicality of the EP for analysing factors in reshoring decision-making content. By identifying these two types of factors, and thus bridging the gap between decision factors and influencing factors. This paper establishes a structured analytical framework. For practitioners, the findings highlight the importance of understanding the multifaceted nature of decision factors, which is very important for making well-informed decisions.

Within the thesis, Paper I directly supports the formulation of research questions, and the foundation for other studies. It contributes to RQ1 by identifying and categorising key decision factors in manufacturing reshoring decision-making. It also contributes to RQ2 by conceptualising how decision factors and influencing factors are related and how they can be categorised through the EP. By integrating these factors with resource-seeking, market-seeking, efficiency-seeking, and strategic asset-seeking advantages, Paper I develops a theory-informed framework for analysing reshoring decision-making content.

It further contributes to RQ3 by highlighting the dynamic and context-dependent nature of reshoring decision-making. The identification of hybrid-seeking factors highlights the context-dependent and multifaceted role of decision factors. Such factors cannot be interpreted in isolation. This paper advances a more holistic understanding of reshoring decision-making content and establishes a robust conceptual foundation for this thesis.

Paper I provides a structured way for practitioners to interpret reshoring decisions. To make well-informed decisions, it is important to assess the

decision-making content through different perspectives based on their contextual role. By clarifying how reshoring decision-making has been conceptualised in existing research, Paper I contributes to greater conceptual clarity and provides a coherent basis for both academic analysis and managerial decision-making.

4.2 Paper II: Exploring drivers, barriers and enablers for manufacturing reshoring in the Nordic countries

4.2.1 Research background

Manufacturing reshoring has gained increasing attention, as it is an important strategy for firms to respond to rising global uncertainty and disruptions (Barbieri *et al.*, 2018; Boffelli *et al.*, 2020). Prior research has primarily focused on identifying reshoring motivations or the reasons behind the initiatives (i.e., drivers), the other two perspectives, barriers and enablers, have received limited attention (Engström *et al.*, 2018a; Stentoft *et al.*, 2018). It is necessary to understand them in an integrated manner.

The Nordic countries provide a relevant and distinctive context for reshoring research. They are characterised by advanced industrial capabilities, high labour costs, and high levels of automation and sustainability. Within the Nordic context, reshoring studies have primarily concentrated on drivers of reshoring in individual countries, particularly Sweden, Denmark, and Finland (e.g. Johansson and Olhager, 2018a; Heikkilä *et al.*, 2018a; 2018b). Very few studies have examined barriers (e.g. Engström *et al.*, 2018a; 2018b), and even fewer have explored enablers. These factors have rarely been analysed together.

Paper II addresses this gap by examining how drivers, barriers, and enablers jointly shape reshoring decisions. It also provides knowledge on how the role may shift depending on context and decision circumstances. The EP is used as a structuring framework to examine how these factors operate across reshoring cases, enabling a systematic comparison. By locating reshoring decisions within the Nordic industrial context and adopting a role-based analytical approach, Paper II provides an integrated understanding of how drivers, barriers, and enablers jointly shape reshoring decisions.

4.2.2 Findings

The findings of Paper II are based on 489 coded interview quotes from 16 manufacturing firms. The analysis identified 65 drivers, 32 barriers, and 38 enablers, showing that reshoring decisions are shaped by the simultaneous presence of drivers, barriers, and enablers (Table 6). Drivers were most frequently mentioned, while barriers and enablers played important roles in shaping feasibility and implementation.

Table 6 Decision factors as drivers (D), barriers (B), and enablers (E)

EP	Decision factors	# of quotes	Respondents															
			ID1	ID2	ID3	ID4	ID5	ID6	ID7	ID8	ID9	ID10	ID11	ID12	ID13	ID14	ID15	ID16
RS*	Labour resources	33	D/B	D	D	B/E			D/B/E	B/E	E	D		B		D/B		
	Production foundation	5	D/B	D	D		E		D									
MS*	Customer service	12			D	D	D		D	D		D		D				
	Industrial agglomeration	2	D															
	Labour cost	15		D	D			D	D/B	D/B/E	B					D		
	Logistics performance	31	D/B	D	D	D	D	D	D	D/E		D		D				
	Patriotism	7	D	D	D				D	D		D				D		D
	Raw material access & cost	4				D/B				D								
	Service facilities	2					E			E								
ES*	Controllability of production	32	D	D		D	D		D	D	D	D			D		D	D
	Coordination cost	8	D		D/E				D				D	D				D
	Delivery lead time	36	D/B	D	D	D	D	D	D/E	D		D	D	D			D	
	External communication	17		D		D/E			D	D				D		D		D
	Function synchronisation	28			D	D/E	D/E	D	D	D/B/E	D/E	D	D	D		D		D
	Geographical & cultural distance	22	D	D	D/E	D/E	E	D	D	D								
	Global economic conditions	1							D									
	IT	1	D															
	Inventory level & cost	19	D/B	D/E	D					B/E		D	D		D		D	
	Labour market flexibility	9							B	D/B	B		B			B	D	
	Labour productivity	3		D														
	Macroeconomics	3							D			D						
	Manufacturing capacity	30		E		B/E	D	E	B	D/B/E	D/E	D	D				B/E	
	Manufacturing cost	25	D/B			B/E		D	D	D	D		D		D	D	B	
	Manufacturing risks	15			D	D	D	D	D	D/B	D/B				D	D		
	Overhead cost	22		B	D	B/E		D	D/B	D/B	D/B		D/B			D		
	Political stability	2	D							E								
	Production flexibility	29		D		D	D	D	D	D		D		D	D		D	
	Replenishment lead time	6			D			D		D				D			D	
	Social/ethical concerns	1								D								
	Subsidies	1	D															
	Supply chain flexibility	4				D				D		D	D					
	Supply chain risks	20	D		D	D	D		D	D	D	D	D		D			D
	Supply chain visibility	3	D															
	Time to market	15	D	D	D	D/B		D	D/E	D				D			D	D

EP	Decision factors	# of quotes	Respondents															
			ID1	ID2	ID3	ID4	ID5	ID6	ID7	ID8	ID9	ID10	ID11	ID12	ID13	ID14	ID15	ID16
	Total cost	55	D/B		D	B		D	D	D/B/E	D/E	D		D	D	D	D/B	D
	Trade & payment terms	2					D			D								
	Logistics cost	13				D	D	D	D	D		D	D	D		D		
SAS*	Competitive pressure	6					D	D		D	D							
	Competitive priorities	12	E		E	E	D	D	D	D	D		D					
	Core competencies	18				D/B		D/E	D	D/B/E	D/E		D				D	
	Brand image & reputation	7	D			D					D		D					D
	Innovation ability	2	D				D											
	Production & process quality	12	D			D	E		D/E			E						
	Responsible supply chain	4							D		D	D						D
	Servitisation strategy	1							D									
	Strategy shift	5	E	E			D		E									
	Technology agglomeration	1									D							
	Ownership related issues	2	B							B								
	Strategic flexibility	2							E		E							
HS*	Currency exchange rate	13	D/B	D			D	D	D	D/B							D	D
	Customisation strategy	5							D								D	
	Business partners	18	D/B/E		E	B			D	D/B	D/E							
	Customer demand	20	D	D	D/E	D/B/E	E	D	D/E	D		D			D	D	D/B	D
	Customer proximity	27		D	D/E	D/E	D/E	D	D/E	D	D/E							
	Facilities & equipment	22	B	E	E	D/B/E		D	B	D/B/E	E		D/B					
	Government incentives	8	D	B/E	E				B	E								
	Infrastructure	15	D	D	D		E	D		D/B/E	E		E					
	Know-how & IP	33	D/B	D	E	D/E	D/E		D	B/E	B	E		D		E	D	D
	Knowledge & technology	13	D		D/E			D		D	D/B		D	D		E	D	
	Legislation & regulations	18	D	B/E		B	D		B	D/B/E	D		B		D		D	
	Made-in effect	16	D		D	D	D			D				D			D	D
	Management performance	12	D	D		E			D/E	D/B	D/B/E	D						D
	Market opportunities	19		D	D	B/E		D	E	E	E	D	D		D		D	
	Product quality	44	D	D	D	D	D		D	D	D	D		D	D	D		D
	R&D	6					D		D	D	D		D					D
	Responsiveness to market	15	D	D	D	D		D				D	D	D	D		D	D
	Supply networks	20	D		E	D	D/E	E	D	D/B/E	D/E							
	Sustainable supply chain	15				D/B/E	D	D		D	D	D	D					D
	Manufacturing automation level	11	B/E		E				B/E	E	B							

Most drivers reflect efficiency-seeking consideration, particularly related to cost consideration and operational efficiency, factors such as total cost, controllability of production, delivery lead time, and supply chain risks were repeatedly highlighted as key motivations for reshoring. Market-seeking advantages were also highlighted as important drivers, including logistics performance and customer proximity; strategic asset-seeking drivers, such as product quality, and know-how & IP contribute to company's long-term competitiveness.

Barriers to reshoring were also primarily associated with efficiency-seeking and strategic asset-seeking considerations. In the Nordic industrial context, high labour, overhead, and total costs, along with limited access to specialised labour and production equipment, were frequently reported barriers. Firms also faced challenges related to ownership structures, immobile assets, and missing competencies developed during offshoring phases. A key finding is that the same factors that encourage reshoring may also impede the process.

Enablers were mainly linked to manufacturing readiness and their capabilities in completing reshoring. Key enablers included available manufacturing capacity, skilled labour, know-how & IP, infrastructure, and the automation level of the production configuration. Strategic flexibility, function synchronisation across departments, and strong internal coordination were also identified as key enablers that facilitate successful implementation. In this category, some enablers also found overlapping with barriers, which means the role of the same factor can shift depending on conditions.

Besides the drivers that are usually discussed in current literature, firms should consider what barriers that might impede reshoring and which enablers that can overcome or lower the impacts from uncertainties, to make well-informed decisions. Across all three roles, some factors present hybrid-seeking characteristics, functioning as drivers, barriers, or enablers depending on contextual conditions. The non-linear, contingent and dynamic nature of reshoring decision-making was evident in the Nordic manufacturing context.

4.2.3 Contribution to the thesis

Building on the conceptual foundation established in Paper I, Paper II provides empirical evidence of how decision factors function as drivers, barriers, and enablers in manufacturing reshoring decisions in the Nordic context. It contributes directly to RQ1 by identifying *what* are key drivers, barriers, and enablers and to RQ2 by showing *how* these influencing roles jointly shape reshoring decisions. It also adds a region-specific and empirically grounded perspective to the thesis.

Paper II also supports RQ3 by showing the same decision factor may assume different influencing roles depending on firms' readiness, external

conditions, and the decision context. A factor may trigger, impede, or facilitate reshoring under different conditions. This provides empirical evidence of role dynamics and reinforces the context-dependent nature of reshoring decision-making content.

4.3 Paper III: Reshoring decisions in the deglobalisation era: exploring influencing factors with the Eclectic Paradigm

4.3.1 Research background

Manufacturing relocation has long been a central production strategy adopted by firms seeking to enhance competitiveness and align manufacturing configuration with overall business strategy. In the pursuit of competitive advantage, companies have relocated manufacturing to locations considered advantageous. Two primary directions of relocation have been identified through the past decades: offshoring (i.e., from the home country to a foreign location), and reshoring (i.e., from previously offshored location back to the home country) (Boffelli *et al.*, 2020; Nujen *et al.*, 2019).

In the past decade, the growing deglobalisation trend was accelerated by geopolitical instability, trade tensions and supply chain vulnerabilities. As such, reshoring is increasingly seen as a way to mitigate these risks while improving supply chain resilience, control, and responsiveness. Prior empirical reshoring research has extensively identified factors that motivate or drive reshoring (Boffelli *et al.*, 2020; Bettiol *et al.*, 2023). That was only one perspective for the whole decision-making content. Much of the empirical literature has examined factors in isolation and remains conceptually fragmented. Despite calls for stronger theoretical grounding in reshoring research, factors have rarely been analysed through established international manufacturing theories.

Scholars have increasingly emphasised the need for qualitative and theory-driven studies that capture the complexity, contextuality, and dynamic nature of reshoring decision-making (Engström *et al.*, 2018b; McIvor and Bals, 2021; Moradlou *et al.*, 2021). In response, Paper III aims to examine the factors influencing manufacturing reshoring decisions and to analyse how these factors shape decision-making content within a specific contextual setting. Drawing on in-depth interviews with managers directly involved in reshoring projects, the EP is applied as the theoretical lens for data analysis. It conceptualises location decisions in terms of resource-seeking, market-seeking, efficiency-seeking, and strategic asset-seeking (Dunning, 1998), and has strong potential to structure factors within decision-making content. Its application of it is still limited in empirical reshoring studies.

4.3.2 Findings

Paper III identifies a broad set of factors influencing manufacturing reshoring decisions. Based on 489 empirical quotes, 69 influencing factors were identified and structured through the EP. These factors span resource-seeking (3%), market-seeking (10%), efficiency-seeking (41%), and strategic asset-seeking (17%) categories. A substantial share (29%) exhibit hybrid-seeking characteristics, indicating that one factor can be multiple seeking at the same time. Efficiency-seeking considerations are primarily shaped the reshoring decisions.

Those influencing factors Paper III identified are most frequently operated as reshoring drivers. Together with barriers or enablers, reshoring decisions are shaped by a combination of motivating forces, constraints, and enabling conditions. Figure 11 synthesises these findings by mapping the underlying factors across the strategic categories and their influencing roles in reshoring decision-making. The figure illustrates the multidimensional and context-dependent nature of reshoring decisions Paper III observed.

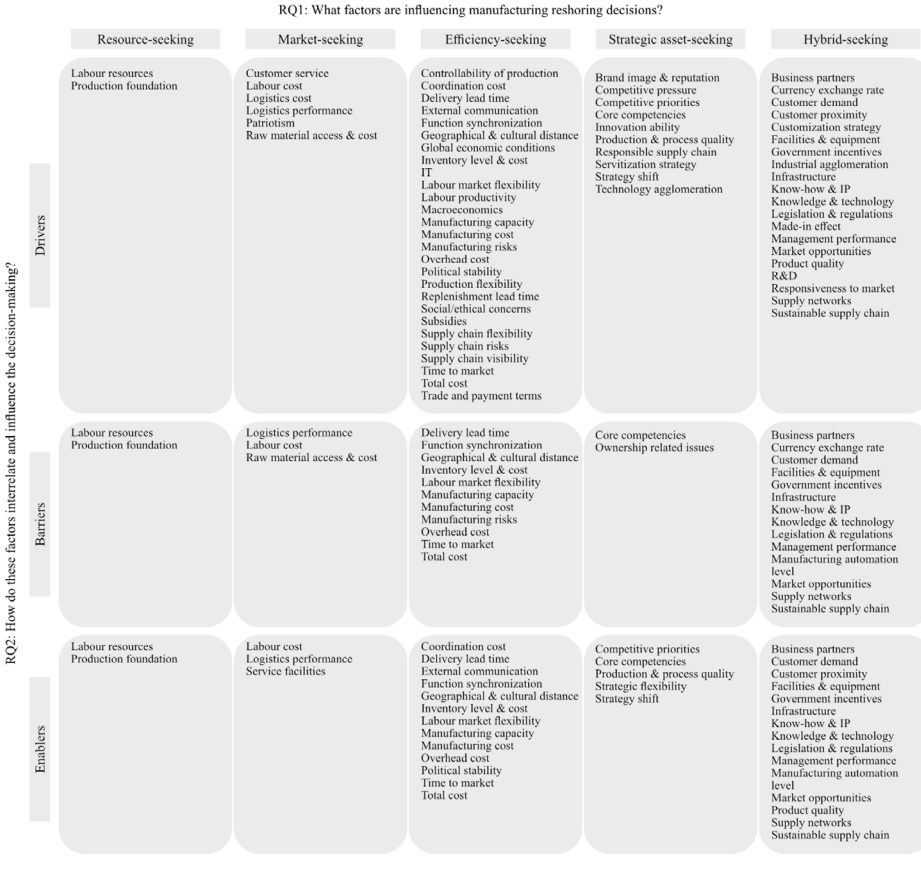


Figure 11 Decision-making framework of influencing factors

Efficiency-seeking factors, such as production controllability, cost structures, lead times, production flexibility, and supply chain risks, were particularly frequently mentioned. It reflects firms' efforts in addressing inefficiencies experienced in offshore manufacturing. At the same time, cost-related factors also emerged as key barriers, reflecting the trade-offs between operational efficiency gains and cost pressures. Market-seeking advantages were mainly associated with logistics performance, customer service, and customer proximity. Strategic asset-seeking influencing factors related to maintaining core competencies, production and process quality, and competitive positioning. A significant number of hybrid-seeking influencing factors were identified, such as know-how and intellectual property (IP), infrastructure, automation level, regulations, and customer demand. These factors were found to operate as drivers, barriers, or enablers depending on context.

4.3.3 Contribution to the thesis

Paper III provides an empirical basis for understanding the factors that influence manufacturing reshoring decisions in the deglobalisation era. Using the EP as a theoretical lens, Paper III identifies and structures a comprehensive set of influencing factors and demonstrates how these factors operate differently depending on strategic intentions. The study shows how uncertainty, geopolitical tensions, and supply chain vulnerabilities shape contemporary reshoring decision-making.

Within the thesis, Paper III contributes directly to RQ1 by identifying key influencing factors of manufacturing reshoring decisions, and to RQ2 by examining how these factors interrelate and shape reshoring decision-making content. Paper III complements Paper II's broader analysis of influencing factors by providing empirical evidence of how decision factors can become drivers, barriers, and enablers in practice.

Paper III also supports RQ3 by showing that several influencing factors exhibit hybrid-seeking characteristics and may reflect more than one advantage-seeking logic depending on strategic and contextual conditions. This provides empirical support for advantage-seeking dynamics and reinforces the multidimensional and context-dependent nature of reshoring decision-making content. It strengthens the empirical application of the EP and extends understanding of influencing factors under contemporary deglobalisation pressures.

4.4 Paper IV: Exploring reshoring dynamics through decision-making content: A comparative index analysis in the Nordic context

4.4.1 Research background

Reshoring strategies have gained increasing and renewed attention as geopolitical uncertainty, supply-chain disruptions, and sustainability pressures have prompted firms to reconsider their global manufacturing configurations (Ashby, 2016; Dachs *et al.*, 2019; Pedroletti and Ciabuschi, 2023). These developments have increased the need for contemporary evidence on the factors shaping reshoring decisions (Heikkilä *et al.*, 2018b; Li *et al.*, 2025b) and how their roles and relative priorities vary across decision-making stages and time horizons.

The Nordic manufacturing context is particularly relevant for examining these issues. Nordic countries combine advanced manufacturing capabilities, technological competence, and developed institutional environments with comparatively high labour and operating costs. Reshoring decisions in this context are therefore unlikely to be explained by cost considerations alone. They involve the evaluation of multiple efficiency-, market-, resource-, and strategic asset-seeking advantages.

Existing research has identified a broad range of reshoring drivers, barriers, and enablers, but they are often presented as relatively static and discussed separately. Less is known about how their influencing roles vary, how their relative priorities differ across decision-making stages, and may change over time. Paper IV addresses these gaps through a role-, stage-, and time-sensitive assessment of reshoring decision-making content.

4.4.2 Findings

Paper IV identifies three interrelated forms of dynamics in manufacturing reshoring decision-making content: role, stage, and temporal dynamics, Table 7 shows how one decision factor can be interpreted simultaneously through these three dimensions.

Table 7 Examples of understanding dynamics in reshoring decision-making content

Factor	Role dynamic	Stage dynamic	Temporal dynamic
Total cost	Strongest current driver; limited barrier and enabler roles	Important at both stages; stronger formal priority	Remains high but less dominant
Business partners	Leading current enabler and barrier	Greater formal stage priority	Higher future priority as an enabler
Product quality	Leading current driver; and an enabler	Stronger formal priority	Lower future relative priority

Factor	Role dynamic	Stage dynamic	Temporal dynamic
Labour resources	Both a driver and a barrier	Resource pressure triggers awareness	Resources and productivity gain priority
Energy cost	Low current priority across all roles	Emerging awareness signal	Driver, barrier, and enabler
Manufacturing capacity	Leading current enabler; also related to driver and barrier	Formal feasibility factor	Lower future relative priority
Information access	Low current priority across roles	Not prioritised in either stage	Largest positive future enabler shift
Supply chain resilience	Moderate current driver; limited other roles	Stable priority across stages	Higher future driver and enabler priorities

First, role dynamics show that the influencing role of a decision factor is conditional rather than fixed. The same factor may motivate reshoring, constrain its feasibility, or support it depending on the context. Current Nordic reshoring is efficiency-led but not efficiency-only. Total cost is the strongest current driver, while market-, resource-, and strategic asset-seeking considerations also influence the decision. Labour market flexibility is the leading barrier, whereas business partners, manufacturing automation, and manufacturing capacity are important enablers.

Second, stage dynamics distinguish risk-led awareness from value-led formal assessment. External uncertainty, supply-chain risks, and resource pressures tend to trigger reconsideration of the existing manufacturing configuration. Formal decision involves a broader evaluation of efficiency-, resource-, market-, and strategic assets-seeking advantages. The stage comparison distinguishes awareness-stage triggers from formal decision-making-stage drivers. Total cost is important at both stages but becomes more prominent in formal assessment.

Third, temporal dynamics show that the relative priorities of one decision factor may change over time. Total cost, product quality, and time to market continue to be relevant. Factors associated with energy, labour productivity, raw-material access, resilience, and sustainability gain future priority. Enablers show clear future-oriented patterns, information, technology, knowledge, and flexibility are highly related to firms' readiness. The findings indicate a shift from reliance on available manufacturing capacity towards broader capability readiness.

4.4.3 Contribution to the thesis

Paper IV provides the main empirical basis for examining the dynamic nature of manufacturing reshoring decision-making content through role, stage, and temporal perspectives. It incorporates temporal and stage-specific dimensions in decision-making, strengthening contemporary understanding. Within the

thesis, it contributes to RQ1 by identifying and ranking current drivers, barriers, and enablers and by showing that Nordic reshoring is efficiency-led but not efficiency-only. It supports RQ2 by demonstrating that the same decision factor may assume different influencing roles and that reshoring decisions depend on the balance between expected advantages, feasibility constraints, and implementation readiness.

Paper IV contributes directly to RQ3 by operationalising three interrelated forms of dynamics. Role dynamics explain how factors influence reshoring; stage dynamics explain when factors become salient; and temporal dynamics explain how their relative priorities are expected to evolve. The paper identifies role, stage, and temporal dynamics in reshoring decision-making content. Methodologically, it also introduces a comparative index-based approach for examining factors' relative priorities.

4.5 Paper V: Unveiling the Eclectic Paradigm in manufacturing location decisions: applications, limitations and practical guidance

4.5.1 Research background

Manufacturing location decision-making has been increasingly complex as current turbulent global environments and frequently changing competitive conditions. To explain how these location and relocation decisions are made in a systematic way, research has relied on established theoretical frameworks. Traditionally, these decisions have been analysed using theories such as TCE (Williamson, 1975; 1985), and the RBV (Barney, 1991). TCE primarily focuses on cost efficiency and governance mode, and RBV emphasises firm-specific competitive advantages. Both theories tend to explain only parts of the perspectives. The EP (Dunning, 1998), on the other hand, integrates multiple perspectives.

The EP has been regarded as a key theory in international business (Stoian and Filippaios, 2008). It is widely used in international business research to explain the reasons behind multinational enterprises' foreign direct investment behaviours and cross-border activities (Casadei and Iammarino, 2023; Wiesmann *et al.*, 2017). The first version of the EP (Dunning, 1979) was also be called as OLI parameters, which conceptualised through ownership, location, and internalisation advantages. Dunning progressively extended the framework to address criticisms raised with the theory development, incorporating different strategic motives in his latest EP framework—resource-seeking, market-seeking, efficiency-seeking, and later strategic asset-seeking—to better reflect firms' internationalisation strategies.

Despite its theoretical richness, the application of the EP in manufacturing location and relocation research has been inconsistent. Many studies refer to

the paradigm only as the “OLI framework”, overlooking the interactions between OLI parameters and the advantage-seeking logics. Issues in application have led to fragmented interpretations of the theory and limited the explanatory power in contemporary research.

Paper V aims to develop a clearer and more consistent understanding of the EP and its application in location decision-making, thereby enhancing its explanatory power. By revisiting the theory’s development, limitations, and examining its applications, rather than introducing new empirical evidence. Paper V synthesises conceptual insights into how the EP should be understood and applied in a coherent manner.

4.5.2 Findings

Paper V summarises the conceptual development of the EP, clarifies the relationship between the OLI parameters and the advantage-seeking logics, as well as critically summarises theory limitations. The findings show that although the EP is frequently cited, its application in manufacturing location research remains limited and inconsistent. Most manufacturing location studies do not use the EP as a primary analytical lens. Several papers mention the paradigm or its related concepts in background sections, without further integrating it. Other studies combine the EP with multiple theoretical perspectives. A small set of literature adopts the EP explicitly to structure and interpret manufacturing location decisions.

Among studies that apply the EP, many simply refer the EP as OLI framework (it was only the first version of the EP), often with a narrow focus on location advantages. Four advantage-seeking categories are resource-seeking, market-seeking, efficiency-seeking, and strategic asset-seeking are frequently categorised solely under the location parameter. To clarify the relationship between the three OLI parameters and advantage-seeking logics within the EP, a strategic positioning matrix was developed (Table 8). Firm roles were categorised into three main types (i.e., builder, seeker, and absorber), which are combined with the advantage-seeking logics.

A closer examination of Dunning’s later work shows that this interpretation neglects the interactions. Plus, inconsistent terminology across studies, “the Eclectic Paradigm”, “the eclectic theory”, “the OLI framework”, and “the OLI model” are often used, but these are actually different in conceptual scopes. The findings suggest future studies should use the term with a comprehensive understanding, to avoid fragmented applications of the theory. Different versions of the EP are cited in the same paper without acknowledging their conceptual differences. This further causes inconsistent theoretical interpretations.

Table 8 Strategic Positioning Matrix of practitioner roles in location decision-making

	Resource-seeking	Market-seeking	Efficiency-seeking	Strategic asset-seeking
Ownership parameter	Resource builders · Ot-advantages include the ability to access and harness differences in the distribution of natural and created assets.	Market builders · Country-specific resources and capabilities of firms · All asset-exploiting investment · Trademarks, goodwill.	Efficiency builders · Oa-advantages based on efficiency (e.g., exchange rates, or discount capital at higher rates of interest will be tempted to invest) · Digitalisation-enabled process optimisation and Industry 4.0 operational capabilities	Strategic asset builders · Investment designed to augment resources and capabilities · Capabilities related to technological upgrading and sustainability-oriented innovation.
Location parameter	Resource seekers · Availability, quality, and price of natural resources · Possession of related infrastructure	Market seekers · Demand-related variables (e.g., size, character and potential growth of local and adjacent markets) · Presence of competitors · Given production and transport costs · Clustering of industrial consumers · Government policy (e.g., regulations, import controls)	Efficiency seekers · Competitive advantages of labour, land, and infrastructure · Incentives, concessionary rights for exploitation of advantages · Availability, quality, and price of transportation costs · Economies of scale and scope · Tax advantages, incentives	Strategic asset seekers · Location and price of created/acquired assets. · Exchange rates · Local accumulation of knowledge and exchange of information, and learning experiences
Internalisation parameter	Resource absorbers · Capturing coordinating and transactional benefits of common governance of related activities · Ensure stability of supplies at right price	Market absorbers · Reducing moral hazard and adverse selection · Minimising customers' ignorance or uncertainty	Efficiency absorbers · Cutting transaction and coordination costs · Streamlining supply chain operations and enhancing logistical efficiencies · Improving cost efficiency by internalising key operations and manufacturing processes.	Strategic asset absorbers · Leveraging learning and experience-related assets · Gaining advantages from R&D-related activities · Strengthening competitive prow ess by augmenting intellectual assets.

4.5.3 Contribution to the thesis

Paper V provides the theoretical foundation for understanding how the EP should be understood and applied in a coherent manner. This directly supports the conceptual framework developed in Paper I and grounds the empirical analyses in Papers II and III. It also enhances analytical consistency across studies by offering clear guidance on terminology, theoretical scope, and categorisation logic. This supports consistent interpretation across the thesis.

Through development of the Strategic Positioning Matrix, Paper V provides an integrated framework that explains how OLI parameters and advantage-seeking logics interact to shape manufacturing location decisions. Within the thesis, Paper V contributes primarily to RQ2 by resolving ambiguities in the relationship between OLI parameters and the advantage-seeking logics. It also supports RQ3 by conceptualising dynamic role shifts through the firm roles of builders, seekers, and absorbers.

Paper V serves as a theoretical backbone of the thesis. It bridges theory and practice by translating conceptual insights into actionable guidance for scholars and practitioners. The Strategic Positioning Matrix enables structured analysis of how firm roles and advantage-seeking logics shape the interpretation of decision factors together. It extends the practical application of the EP while providing clearer guidance for its use in manufacturing location decision-making.

4.6 Result synthesis

This section synthesises the perspectives and key findings of the appended papers and shows how they collectively address the RQs. The key findings of papers and how they are answering RQs are synthesised in Table 9.

Table 9 Synthesis of paper findings and contributions to the RQs

Paper #	RQ1: *What are the key factors firms consider in manufacturing reshoring decision-making?*	RQ2: *How do these key factors interrelate and influence manufacturing reshoring decisions?*	RQ3: *How do shifts in decision-making content reflect the dynamic nature of manufacturing reshoring?*
I	Conceptually identifies and differentiates *decision factors* and *influencing factors*, establishing the analytical scope of reshoring decision-making content	Conceptualises how decision and influencing factors interact under the EP lens.	Identifies advantage-seeking dynamics by conceptualising hybrid-seeking factors that may reflect multiple advantage-seeking categories.

Paper #	RQ1: *What are the key factors firms consider in manufacturing reshoring decision-making?*	RQ2: *How do these key factors interrelate and influence manufacturing reshoring decisions?*	RQ3: *How do shifts in decision-making content reflect the dynamic nature of manufacturing reshoring?*
II	Empirically identifies reshoring *influencing factors* under the deglobalisation era, with the EP.	Analyses interrelationships among influencing factors across resource-, market-, efficiency-, strategic asset-, and hybrid-seeking logics.	Provides empirical evidence of role and advantage-seeking dynamics, showing influencing factors are context-dependent with hybrid-seeking characteristics.
III	Identifies key reshoring *drivers*, *barriers*, and *enablers* under the Nordic manufacturing context.	Demonstrates how factors shift roles *(driver/barrier/enabler)* and jointly influence reshoring decisions.	Shows dynamic role changes of factors across reshoring cases and decision contexts.
IV	Identifies and ranks current reshoring *drivers*, *barriers*, and *enablers*, showing Nordic reshoring decision-making is efficiency-led but not efficiency-only.	Provides secondary evidence that the same decision factor may assume different influencing roles.	Identifies role, stage, and temporal dynamics.
V		Consolidates the strategic logic and integrates OLI parameters with strategic advantage-seeking logic via the Strategic Positioning Matrix.	Extends advantage-seeking dynamics by linking OLI parameters with advantage-seeking logics, and firm roles, and presents the Strategic Positioning Matrix.

5. Discussion

This chapter presented the discussion. The discussion is structured around the three RQs. First, the key decision factors shaping reshoring decisions are identified and categorised. Second, the interrelationships among these factors and their influencing roles are analysed. Third, the chapter examines how reshoring decision-making content evolves across contexts, strategic priorities, and time, and thus reflects the reshoring dynamics.

5.1 RQ1: What are the key factors firms consider in manufacturing reshoring decision-making?

RQ1 seeks to identify and understand the key factors that firms consider when deciding to reshore manufacturing activities. Prior research has identified a wide range of factors influencing reshoring, but these factors have often been examined in fragmented ways. Developing an integrated understanding that summarises their roles and relative importance provides deeper insight into reshoring decision-making content. In this thesis, decision factors refer to the substantive considerations included in reshoring decision-making content, such as labour resources, manufacturing costs, logistics performance, customer proximity, product quality, production flexibility, sustainability, and knowledge-related capabilities (Engström *et al.*, 2018a; 2018b; Johansson *et al.*, 2019; Wiesmann *et al.*, 2017).

A clearer and integrated understanding of decision-making content can improve the likelihood of successful reshoring implementation, as well as strengthen firm's long-term competitiveness. Based on the findings from Papers I–IV, the identified decision factors are organised into five categories extracted from the EP (Dunning, 1998) based on the type of strategic advantage they represent: resource-seeking, market-seeking, efficiency-seeking, strategic asset-seeking, or hybrid-seeking. The existence of hybrid-seeking demonstrates reshoring decisions are not based on isolated considerations, but on combinations of strategic objectives and operational priorities. This section focuses on presenting the key factors firms considered in the reshoring decision-making based on the EP.

5.1.1 Resource-seeking decision factors

Resource-seeking decision factors concern firm's access to and ability to leverage critical production resources. In reshoring decision-making, these factors relate to whether firms can access or rebuild resources needed to relocate

manufacturing activities back home. Such resources may include skilled labour, infrastructure, production facilities and equipment, business partners, and favourable currency conditions (Dunning, 1998; Ellram *et al.*, 2013; Ancarani *et al.*, 2015).

The findings show that resource-seeking factors appear less frequently than other strategic advantages, especially efficiency-seeking, but the empirical findings still confirm their continued relevance (Table 10). One explanation may be that globalisation has reduced resource scarcity across locations, shifting firms' focus from resource access to resource utilisation efficiency. Still, findings show that reshoring cannot be implemented without sufficient domestic resources, such as labour resources, facilities and equipment, business partners, and production foundation. Without these essential resources, firms cannot prepare the organisational capabilities and readiness required to reshore.

Table 10 Resource-seeking decision factors

Decision factor	Description
Business partners	Availability of suitable suppliers, partners, and supporting actors in the home country
Currency exchange rate	Currency-related conditions affecting the location attractiveness
Facilities & equipment	Availability of reliable production facilities and equipment that are necessary for production
Labour resources	Availability of skilled and qualified labour
Natural resources	Access to raw materials or natural resources with reasonable price
Production foundation	Availability of existing production base, capabilities, and reshoring readiness

5.1.2 Market-seeking decision factors

Market-seeking decision factors concern firms' ability to access, serve, and respond to target markets. Findings show that market-seeking advantages also play an important role in shaping reshoring decisions (Table 11). These factors reflect the importance of being closer to customers, increasing customer satisfaction by improving service, responding to changing demand, and strengthening market positioning. Compared to traditional offshoring motivations, which often emphasised labour cost differences (Casadei and Iammarino, 2023), the reshoring literature increasingly highlights the importance of market responsiveness and customer value creation. This reflects a broader strategic shift towards service-oriented manufacturing offerings.

The findings show that firms consider market-seeking factors when reshoring is expected to improve their ability to better serve target markets or exploit potential markets. Interestingly, findings also show that customers value domestic production or country-of-origin associations, factors such as patriotism

and the made-in effect (categorised in hybrid-seeking) may influence market attractiveness.

Table 11 Market-seeking decision factors

Decision factor	Description
Customer proximity	Proximity to customers and target markets
Customer service	Ability to improve customer service
Patriotism	Customer or stakeholder preference for domestic production
Service facilities	Availability of facilities supporting customer service

5.1.3 Efficiency-seeking decision factors

Efficiency-seeking decision factors form the largest group of reshoring decision factors identified across the thesis, in both literature review and empirical studies. Efficiency-seeking advantages focus on achieving cost efficiency and operational effectiveness through optimising the allocation of activities across locations. These factors typically relate directly or indirectly to production costs, including manufacturing cost, manufacturing capacity, labour market flexibility, geographical and cultural distance, and overall supply chain efficiency (Ancarani *et al.*, 2015; 2019; Hartman *et al.*, 2017). The dominance of efficiency-seeking factors indicates that firms prioritise trade-offs between operational performance and cost efficiency, even when reshoring to developed economies.

The findings show that firms continue to evaluate reshoring through cost-related and operational trade-offs. Firms consider broader system-level efficiency, including total cost, manufacturing cost, logistics cost, inventory levels, coordination, controllability, production flexibility, supply chain risk, and time to market (Table 12). The dominance of efficiency-seeking factors suggests that firms aim to balance between cost and operational performance when evaluating reshoring. These findings suggest that reshoring decisions involve balancing cost efficiency with operational responsiveness and strategic flexibility. The trade-off is more complex than a simple comparison of costs between relocation alternatives. For example, firms may reshore even when the home country has higher direct manufacturing costs, it is because reshoring can improve coordination, flexibility, delivery reliability, or overall controllability. Even though most factors identified are in this category, this does not mean they are necessarily the most important, or influential, but rather the most common. The relative importance of these factors was later investigated and presented in Section 5.3.

Table 12 Efficiency-seeking decision factors

Decision factor	Description
Coordination cost	To reduce coordination-related costs
Controllability of production	To improve control over production activities
Delivery lead time	To shorten delivery lead times
Energy cost	To evaluate conditions affecting energy-related production costs
External communication	To improve communication with external actors
Function synchronisation	To coordinate production and related functions
Geographical & cultural distance	To shorten distance on coordination between two cultures, and geographical distance to improve operational efficiency
Global economic conditions	Conditions affecting operational and economic stability
Information technology	To integrate resources, support operations through IT systems
Information transfer	To enable transfer information efficiently and accurately
Inventory level & cost	To optimise inventory levels and related costs
Labour cost	Conditions affecting labour-related production costs
Labour market flexibility	Availability of flexible labour market conditions
Labour productivity	To have higher labour productivity
Logistics cost	To reduce logistics-related costs by shorten distances
Logistics performance	To improve logistics reliability and performance
Macroeconomics	Conditions affecting the wider economic environment
Manufacturing capacity	Availability of sufficient manufacturing capacity
Manufacturing cost	To optimise manufacturing-related costs
Manufacturing risks	To reduce risks affecting manufacturing activities
Natural disasters	To reduce disruption caused by natural hazards
Overhead cost	Conditions affecting overhead-related costs
Political stability	Conditions affecting political and institutional stability
Production flexibility	To adjust production volume, mix, or processes
Replenishment lead time	To shorten replenishment lead times
Social/ethical concerns	Conditions affecting ethical and social acceptability
Societal disruptions	To reduce disruptions affecting society and operations
Strategic flexibility	To adapt manufacturing strategy to changing conditions
Subsidies	Access to financial support reducing operational costs
Supply chain agility	To respond rapidly to supply chain changes
Supply chain flexibility	To adapt supply chain configuration and operations
Supply chain resilience	To withstand and recover from disruptions
Supply chain risks	To reduce risks affecting supply chain operations
Supply chain visibility	To improve visibility across the supply chain
Time to market	To shorten time from production to market
Total cost	To optimise total cost across the value chain
Trade & payment terms	Conditions affecting trade and payment arrangements

5.1.4 Strategic asset-seeking decision factors

Strategic asset-seeking advantages constitute the second largest group of factors identified across the thesis (Table 13). Strategic asset-seeking decision factors concern firms' efforts to protect, develop, or access strategic assets through reshoring. These factors related to long-term competitiveness have become increasingly prominent in reshoring decisions (Pal *et al.*, 2018; Gillani *et al.*, 2023). These include considerations related to product quality, brand image, innovation capability, core competencies, and environmental and social sustainability.

The findings also show that strategic asset-seeking factors have become increasingly important. Particularly, stricter environmental regulations and sustainability expectations, especially within the European context, have elevated sustainability considerations in manufacturing location decisions. While strategic asset-seeking factors remain less dominant than efficiency-seeking considerations, their growing importance reflects firms' increasing focus on capability development and long-term strategic positioning.

Table 13 Strategic asset-seeking decision factors

Decision factor	Description
Brand image & reputation	Contribution of manufacturing location to corporate image and reputation
Competitive pressure	Strategic pressure from competitors, customers, or market expectations
Competitive priorities	Alignment between manufacturing location and competitive priorities
Core competencies	Protection, retention, or development of key manufacturing capabilities
Countertrade requirements	Strategic requirements related to market access or exchange conditions
Innovation ability	Ability to support innovation through proximity, knowledge, and capability development
Knowledge transfer	Ability to transfer, retain, and develop knowledge across organisational units
Ownership-related issues	Ownership of tools, patents, know-how, or production-related assets
Product quality	Ability to improve or maintain product quality through location choice
Production & process quality	Ability to improve process reliability and production quality
Servitisation strategy	Support for service-oriented business models and integrated offerings
Strategy shift	Alignment between reshoring and broader strategic repositioning
Tax advantages	Strategic financial or institutional advantages linked to location choice

5.1.5 Hybrid-seeking decision factors

The findings also show that several decision factors cannot be fully understood through a single EP category. Many reshoring factors simultaneously support multiple strategic objectives, exhibiting hybrid-seeking characteristics. For example, know-how & IP may relate to accessing knowledge resources, improving efficiency through better protection of sensitive knowledge, and developing strategic assets (Table 14). Similarly, sustainable supply chain considerations may support market access, cost efficiency, and long-term strategic positioning. These findings support the argument that reshoring decision-making is multidimensional and strategically interconnected. The hybrid-seeking advantages were not explicitly defined within the original EP framework; however, recent research has recognised their relevance in explaining contemporary manufacturing location decisions (Paper I).

Hybrid-seeking factors are important because they show that manufacturing reshoring decision-making is multidimensional and context-dependent. Rather than optimising for a single strategic objective, firms evaluate reshoring through combinations of strategic priorities and operational considerations. Reshoring decision-making is multidimensional and context-dependent, and decision factors should be based on firms' strategic objectives they support.

Table 14 Hybrid-seeking decision factors

Decision factor	Description
Customer demand	**MS:** To access market opportunities by understanding customer needs and demand. **ES:** To improve production efficiency through more accurate demand forecasting. **SAS:** To strengthen the capability to satisfy diverse customer preferences.
Customisation strategy	**MS:** To serve markets with increasing demand for customised products. **ES:** To reduce waste and improve efficiency through more demand-aligned production. **SAS:** To strengthen firms' capability to offer customised solutions.
Government incentives	**RS:** To access incentives and support provided by governments. **ES:** To reduce financial burdens through grants, subsidies, or tax reductions. **SAS:** To strengthen strategic assets by leveraging government-supported development opportunities.
Industrial agglomeration	**MS:** To improve market access and local market understanding through cluster participation. **ES:** To improve responsiveness and production stability through proximity to agglomerative economies.

Decision factor	Description
Information access	**RS:** To access transparent and comprehensive production-related information. **ES:** To improve decision efficiency through better information availability.
Infrastructure	**RS:** To access high-quality infrastructure supporting production resources. **MS:** To support market access through developed infrastructure. **ES:** To improve communication, coordination, and operational efficiency.
Know-how & IP	**RS:** To access local know-how and IP. **ES:** To improve protection of sensitive knowledge and IP. **SAS:** To develop, retain, and strengthen strategic knowledge assets.
Knowledge & technology	**RS:** To access advanced knowledge, technologies, and skills. **SAS:** To strengthen strategic capabilities through technology integration and knowledge development.
Legislation & regulations	**MS:** To access markets shaped by trade regulations and requirements. **ES:** To reduce costs and avoid penalties related to tariffs, restrictions, or non-compliance. **SAS:** To strengthen brand image and legitimacy by meeting strict regulatory and sustainability requirements.
Made-in effect	**MS:** To attract customer groups that value domestic or country-of-origin production. **SAS:** To strengthen brand image through positive country-of-origin associations.
Management performance	**RS:** To access qualified management resources. **ES:** To improve operational efficiency through better management performance.
Manufacturing automation level	**ES:** To increase productivity and reduce production costs through automation. **SAS:** To strengthen production capability, flexibility, and technological competitiveness.
Market opportunities	**MS:** To access new sales and market-opening opportunities. **SAS:** To better understand and exploit potential markets and consumer patterns.
R&D	**ES:** To improve manufacturing efficiency through proximity to R&D activities. **SAS:** To accelerate innovation, product development, and advanced manufacturing capabilities.
Responsible supply chain	**MS:** To access customers who value socially responsible products and production. **ES:** To improve sourcing efficiency through closer and more direct supplier relationships. **SAS:** To strengthen responsible firm image and reduce exposure to human rights risks.
Responsiveness to market	**ES:** To respond quickly to changing demand. **SAS:** To strengthen speed-based competitive capability.

Decision factor	Description
Supply networks	**RS:** To access and cooperate with regional suppliers and supply networks. **MS:** To strengthen local competitiveness through supplier collaboration. **ES:** To improve coordination and efficiency through proximity to suppliers. **SAS:** To leverage the skills, resources, and infrastructure embedded in supply networks.
Sustainable supply chain	**MS:** To attract customer groups that value environmentally responsible production. **ES:** To improve cost efficiency by reducing waste, resource use, and related costs. **SAS:** To strengthen competitive advantage through sustainable supply chain development.
Technology agglomeration	**ES:** To support production innovation through proximity to technology clusters. **SAS:** To access and acquire advanced knowledge through participation in technology clusters, such as industrial parks.

5.2 RQ2: How do these key factors interrelate and influence manufacturing reshoring decisions?

RQ2 investigates how key decision factors interrelate and influence manufacturing reshoring decisions. Rather than acting independently, decision factors interact through trade-offs, complementarities, and enabling mechanisms. This section demonstrates the relational and configurational nature of reshoring decision-making by examining interrelationships among key decision factors and their roles as drivers, barriers, and enablers. The findings suggest that reshoring decisions emerge through the interaction of multiple factors rather than from isolated decision criteria.

5.2.1 Interrelationships among key decision factors

The findings across Papers I–IV show that reshoring decisions are made by evaluating interrelated sets of decision factors that reflect strategic, operational, and contextual considerations. These interactions often take the form of trade-offs, complementarities, and contingent conditions. Figure 12 illustrates the relational logic among key decision factors in manufacturing reshoring decision-making.

The figure conceptualises the dynamic interaction of reshoring decision-making. Drivers trigger reshoring considerations, while barriers constrain feasibility. The relationship between drivers and barriers often involves trade-offs that firms must balance. Enablers facilitate implementation by supporting drivers and mitigating barriers that would otherwise impede reshoring. Together,

this framework demonstrates that reshoring decisions depend on how firms manage the interplay among drivers, barriers, and enablers.

Another important interaction concerns the trade-offs between strategic objectives. For example, efficiency-seeking considerations, such as reducing total manufacturing costs or improving capacity utilisation, often conflict with market-seeking or strategic asset-seeking objectives. Firms in Paper II and Paper III reported that being closer to customers improved delivery speed and service responsiveness, but simultaneously increased labour and overhead costs. This confirms prior findings that reshoring decisions often involve balancing cost efficiency against responsiveness and flexibility (Ellram *et al.*, 2013; Ancarani *et al.*, 2015). These trade-offs imply that the importance of a factor cannot be assessed independently. Gains in one dimension may offset disadvantages in another. As such, reshoring decisions are shaped by relative evaluations.

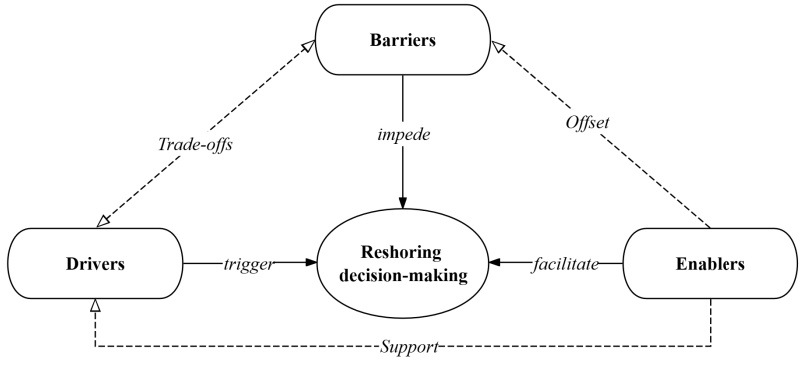


Figure 12 A relational view of reshoring decision-making factors

Beyond trade-offs, the findings show complementarities among key decision factors. Certain factors reinforce each other and jointly increase the feasibility of reshoring. High levels of automation complement skilled labour availability, enabling firms to offset high labour costs while maintaining productivity. Customer proximity improves logistics performance and production flexibility, allowing firms to respond more rapidly to demand changes. The relocation decisions are not about choosing the "best" location but configuring coherent bundles of strategic advantages.

The way decision factors interrelate is conditioned by contingent context, such as industry-, firm-, or product-specific characteristics. Factors that are complementary in one context may become conflicting in another. For example, high automation level may enable efficiency but require substantial investment that might be a barrier for small firms. This supports the view that

reshoring decision-making is contingent and context-dependent (Benstead *et al.*, 2017; Rasel *et al.*, 2020; Moradlou *et al.*, 2021).

5.2.2 Roles of decision factors as drivers, barriers, and enablers

Building on the analysis in Papers I–IV, this thesis shows that reshoring decision factors can exert three interrelated types of influence. The same factor may act as a driver, barrier, or enabler depending on how it is configured, combined with other factors, and interpreted within a specific strategic and contextual setting. This finding also presents the reshoring dynamics by showing their multiple roles. Drivers trigger, barriers impede, and enablers facilitate the reshoring decision-making. These roles are not mutually exclusive, they coexist shaping reshoring decisions through trade-offs, constraints, and supportive mechanisms. As shown in Figure 6, all influencing factors belong to decision factors, while only some decision factors are influencing factors. Table 15 below illustrates the decision factors as drivers, barriers, and enablers.

Drivers trigger or motivate reshoring; it was primarily due to inefficiencies in offshore production or strong attractiveness in the home country's production condition. Empirical findings show that efficiency-seeking drivers dominate reshoring decisions, aligning with prior studies about cost-related or flexibility related factors were major motivations (Ancarani *et al.*, 2021; Lund and Steen, 2020; Moradlou *et al.*, 2021). Managers frequently mentioned that they reshored to reduce total costs, shorten delivery lead times, and enhance controllability and flexibility. Firms' attempts to regain operational control and responsiveness that were difficult to achieve in offshore settings (Rasel *et al.*, 2020; Huq *et al.*, 2021). A substantial share of drivers exhibits hybrid-seeking characteristics, such as access to know-how & IP, which simultaneously support resource-, efficiency-, and strategic asset-seeking objectives (Johansson and Olhager, 2018; Rasel *et al.*, 2020). The presence of strategic asset-seeking advantages indicates firms' willingness to gain access to, create, or maintain strategic and knowledge-related assets. The "made-in" effect strengthens brand image while enhancing customer appeal and market positioning (Grappi *et al.*, 2018; Moretto *et al.*, 2020). Resource-seeking objectives were less mentioned, such as labour and raw material access, were less prominent, one reason could be firms are increasingly motivated by operational reconfiguration rather than resource scarcity (Ellram *et al.*, 2013; Ancarani *et al.*, 2015).

Barriers, on the other hand, impede reshoring decisions by constraining the feasibility, timing, or economic viability. Similar to drivers, a large proportion of barriers fall within the efficiency-seeking category, reflecting the cost and capacity challenges associated with relocating manufacturing back to high-cost contexts. High manufacturing, overhead, and total costs may reduce profitability and thereby slow down reshoring efforts. In some cases, insufficient

domestic capacity and restrictive labour regulations in the home country may further complicate implementation. Some barriers exhibit a multidimensional (i.e., hybrid-seeking) nature. Limited availability of necessary facilities and equipment for production, restrictive regulations, and ownership issues related to tools, patents, and know-how hindered reshoring from efficiency-, resource-, and strategic asset-seeking perspectives based on the context. Market-seeking barriers, such as deteriorating logistics performance further constrained firms' ability to satisfy customers. Reshoring may fail due to a lack of internal capacity or competencies, with strategic intent alone is insufficient without organisational readiness.

Enablers are critical but often underexplored, as they facilitate the translation of reshoring intentions into viable actions, a dimension only sparsely addressed in prior research (Bettiol *et al.*, 2023). Consistent with the drivers and barriers, most identified enablers are efficiency-seeking. The availability of spare manufacturing capacity and inventory in domestic factories emerged as an enabler, aligning with previous studies that identify capacity readiness as reshoring prerequisite (Engström *et al.*, 2018a; Lund and Steen, 2020). Function synchronisation enabled by closer proximity between production, R&D, purchasing, and logistics, has enhanced coordination and operational efficiency (Di Mauro *et al.*, 2018; Heikkilä *et al.*, 2018a). By locating close to the target market, reduced geographical and cultural distance supports smoother collaboration and communication (Engström *et al.*, 2018a).

Table 15 Drivers (D), barriers (B), and enablers (E) under the EP

EP	Decision factor	D	B	E	Reference
RS*	Business partners	X	X	X	Lund and Steen, 2020; Rasel *et al.,* 2020; Sirilertsuwan *et al.,* 2019;
	Currency exchange rate	X	X		Heikkilä *et al.*, 2018a; 2018b; Moretto *et al.,* 2020; Moradlou *et al.,* 2021;
	Facilities & equipment	X	X	X	Engström *et al.*, 2018a; 2018b Heikkilä *et al.*, 2018a; Lund and Steen, 2020;
	Labour resources	X	X	X	Huq *et al.,* 2021; Lund and Steen, 2020; Moradlou *et al.,* 2021; 2022;
	Natural resources	X	X		Engström *et al.,* 2018a; Heikkilä *et al.*, 2018a;
MS*	Customer service	X			Srai and Ané, 2016; Sirilertsuwan *et al.,* 2019;
	Energy cost	X			Ancarani *et al.,* 2021; Martínez-Mora and Merino, 2020;
	Labour cost	X	X		Ancarani *et al.,* 2021; Dachs *et al.,* 2019; Lund and Steen, 2020; Rasel *et al.,* 2020;

EP	Decision factor	D	B	E	Reference
	Logistics performance	X	X		Engström *et al.,* 2018b; Johansson *et al.,* 2019; Moradlou *et al.,* 2021;
	Logistics cost	X	X	X	Ancarani *et al.,* 2021; Lund and Steen, 2020; Rasel *et al.,* 2020;
	Patriotism	X			Engström *et al.,* 2018a; Grappi *et al.*, 2018; Wan *et al.,* 2019;
	Raw material access & cost	X			Ancarani *et al.,* 2021; Heikkilä *et al.*, 2018a; Mohiuddin *et al.,* 2019;
ES*	Controllability of production	X	X	X	Ancarani *et al.,* 2021; Fratocchi, 2018; Huq *et al.,* 2021; Rasel *et al.,* 2020;
	Coordination cost	X		X	Di Mauro *et al.,* 2018; Lund and Steen, 2020; Rasel *et al.,* 2020;
	Customer proximity	X		X	Ancarani *et al.,* 2021; Johansson and Olhager, 2018a; Lund and Steen, 2020;
	Geographical & cultural distance	X		X	Engström *et al.,* 2018b; Huq *et al.,* 2021; Rasel *et al.,* 2020;
	Inventory level & cost	X		X	Engström *et al.,* 2018b; Huq *et al.,* 2021; Moradlou *et al.,* 2021;
	Labour market flexibility	X			Johansson and Olhager, 2018b; Lampón and González-Benito, 2020;
	Manufacturing capacity	X	X	X	Dachs *et al.,* 2019; Engström *et al.,* 2018a; Eriksson *et al.,* 2021; Lund and Steen, 2020;
	Manufacturing cost	X	X	X	Martínez-Mora and Merino, 2020; Młody and Stępień, 2020; Moradlou *et al.,* 2021;
	Production flexibility	X	X	X	Ancarani *et al.,* 2021; Huq *et al.,* 2021; Sequeira *et al.,* 2021;
	Supply chain flexibility	X	X	X	Huq *et al.,* 2021; Lund and Steen, 2020; Sequeira *et al.,* 2021;
	Time to market	X		X	Heikkilä *et al.*, 2018a; 2018b; Moretto *et al.,* 2020; Sequeira *et al.,* 2021;
	Total cost	X	X	X	Ancarani *et al.,* 2021; Rasel *et al.,* 2020; Sequeira *et al.,* 2021;
SAS*	Brand image & reputation	X			Engström *et al.*, 2018a; 2018b Moretto *et al.,* 2020; Rasel *et al.,* 2020;
	Competitive pressure	X	X		Benstead *et al.,* 2017; Heikkilä *et al.*, 2018b; Moradlou *et al.,* 2021;
	Competitive priorities	X		X	Benstead *et al.,* 2017; Nujen *et al.,* 2019;
	Core competencies	X	X		Engström *et al.*, 2018a; 2018b Heikkilä *et al.*, 2018a; 2018b; Johansson and Olhager, 2018b;
	Product quality	X		X	Ancarani *et al.,* 2021; Huq *et al.,* 2021; Sequeira *et al.,* 2021;

EP	Decision factor	D	B	E	Reference
HS*	Customer demand			X	Grappi *et al.*, 2018; Heikkilä *et al.,* 2018a; Huq *et al.,* 2016;
	Government incentives	X		X	Ancarani *et al.,* 2021; Moradlou *et al.,* 2021; Rasel *et al.,* 2020;
	Infrastructure	X	X	X	Dachs *et al.,* 2019; Huq *et al.,* 2021; Sirilertsuwan *et al.,* 2019;
	Know-how & IP	X		X	Ancarani *et al.,* 2021; Huq *et al.,* 2021; Rasel *et al.,* 2020; Moradlou *et al.*, 2021
	Knowledge & technology	X		X	Heikkilä *et al.*, 2018b; Johansson and Olhager, 2018b;
	Legislation & regulations	X	X		Engström *et al.,* 2018b; Huq *et al.,* 2021; Rasel *et al.,* 2020;
	Made-in effect	X	X		Ancarani *et al.,* 2021; Moretto *et al.,* 2020; Rasel *et al.,* 2020;
	Manufacturing automation level	X		X	Lund and Steen, 2020; Młody and Stępień, 2020; Wan *et al.,* 2019;
	Research & development (R&D)	X			Engström *et al.,* 2018a; Lund and Steen, 2020; Moretto *et al.,* 2020; Rasel *et al.,* 2020;
	Responsiveness to market	X		X	Benstead *et al.,* 2017; Huq *et al.,* 2021; Johansson and Olhager, 2018a;
	Supply networks		X	X	Engström *et al.,* 2018b; Nujen *et al.,* 2019; Rasel *et al.,* 2020;
	Technology agglomeration	X		X	Nujen *et al.,* 2019; Młody and Stępień, 2020; Rasel *et al.,* 2020;

*RS=Resource-seeking, MS=Market-seeking, ES=Efficiency-seeking, SAS=Strategic asset-seeking, HS=Hybrid-seeking

5.3 RQ3: How do shifts in decision-making content reflect the dynamic nature of manufacturing reshoring?

RQ3 addresses the dynamic nature of manufacturing reshoring decision-making by examining how decision-making content evolves across roles, advantage-seeking logics, decision-making stages, and time. Paper IV provides the main empirical basis for understanding reshoring dynamics. Findings show that reshoring is not a one-off, static decision. Rather, it is one possible outcome of a broader and ongoing process in which firms continuously assess and reassess. As contexts, strategic priorities, and performance requirements change, firms reassess which manufacturing location configuration is most suitable based on the context.

5.3.1 Dynamics in the roles of influencing factors

A central finding of this thesis is that decision factors may assume different influencing roles such as drivers, barriers, or enablers. Their roles are conditional rather than fixed. The same factor may serve different roles depending

on contingent context, such as country-, industry-, and firm-specific conditions, as well as firm's strategic objectives at that moment, and the broader economic environment. This confirms earlier observations that reshoring decision factors are context-dependent (Benstead *et al.*, 2017; Bettiol *et al.*, 2023; Moore *et al.*, 2018). Beyond solely focus on drivers in earlier research, this thesis explicitly demonstrates role transferability across contexts.

Several decision factors simultaneously act as drivers, barriers, and enablers. For example, manufacturing capacity as a driver when firms reshore to utilise free domestic capacity, but as a barrier when insufficient capacity at home and requires additional investment, which would delay implementation. When spare capacity is available and aligned with production needs, it becomes an enabler, facilitating a smooth reshoring process. Similar shifts were observed for many factors, labour resources, facilities and equipment, and know-how and IP. This view presents the reshoring dynamic from the perspective of factor roles. Reshoring decision-making involves continuous reassessment, where firms reinterpret factors as conditions change. Drivers, barriers, and enablers jointly influence reshoring decisions: drivers create attractiveness, barriers constrain feasibility, and enablers provide implementation readiness that compensate the barriers' negative impacts.

5.3.2 Dynamics across advantage-seeking logics

Another dimension of dynamism lies in how decision factors may be interpreted across advantage-seeking logics. Traditionally, the EP distinguishes determinants between resource-seeking, market-seeking, efficiency-seeking, and strategic asset-seeking advantages (Dunning, 1998). These categories represent different advantage-seeking logics through which firms interpret manufacturing location decisions. The findings show that many factors cannot be meaningfully classified into a single category. Instead, they exhibit hybrid-seeking characteristics.

Several factors have been categorised differently across the reshoring literature and the empirical studies included in this thesis. Customer proximity has often been classified as an efficiency-seeking factor due to its impact on lead times and coordination costs (Ellram, 2013; Ancarani *et al.*, 2015). While findings from Papers II and III show that firms also interpret customer proximity as a market-seeking consideration, enabling better customer service, responsiveness, and value creation. Moradlou *et al.* (2021) similarly treated customer proximity as market-seeking as it facilitates firms to access market opportunities. Know-how & IP is frequently treated as strategic assets in prior studies (McIvor and Bals, 2021), yet empirical evidence demonstrates that they also function as resource- or efficiency-seeking considerations when firms reshore to access or safeguard sensitive knowledge and reduce coordination risks.

Hybrid-seeking characteristic is also evident in institutional and regulatory factors. Legislation and regulations, for example, can be interpreted through several advantage-seeking categories and their underlying logics. From a market-seeking viewpoint, companies find it challenging in accessing market opportunities when governments publish restrictions on trading (Rasel *et al.*, 2020). From an efficiency-seeking viewpoint, legal issues can complicate a company's relocation from a specific country (Engström *et al.*, 2018a; Huq *et al.*, 2021). From a strategic asset-seeking viewpoint, environmental regulations in the home country can require significant adaptations of production (Engström *et al.*, 2018b).

Reshoring decisions may reflect several strategic objectives simultaneously. Firms therefore need to balance or trade-offs among different advantage-seeking logics, and some decision factors exhibit hybrid-seeking characteristics. It also shows how the strategic interpretation of decision factors may change as firms reframe their priorities.

This dynamic interpretation is further supported by the Strategic Positioning Matrix (Table 8) developed in Paper V. The matrix links OLI parameters and advantage-seeking logics. By mapping firm roles in the matrix, it provides a structured way to understand how firms position themselves in manufacturing location decisions. In relation to reshoring, the matrix helps explain that firms need to first evaluate which location alternative is attractive, and then *how* their own capabilities and strategic roles shape related decision factors. Firms may act as builders, seekers, or absorbers. Evaluation of decision factors depends on how firms position themselves strategically, and how it matches with the location alternative.

5.3.3 Dynamics across decision-making stages

Reshoring decision-making develops through multiple stages. Building on the general logic of manufacturing location decision-making introduced earlier, reshoring should be understood as one location alternative. The underlying decision is whether the current manufacturing configuration remains suitable or should be changed; reshoring is one possible alternative. Drawing on Paper IV, two main stages are distinguished: the awareness stage and the formal decision-making stage. The importance and role of decision factors may shift across these stages. The awareness stage is the period when firms recognise misalignment or emerging problems in their current production configuration, prompting a re-evaluation of the manufacturing location strategy. When misalignment between current configuration and their strategic and operational objectives is identified, reshoring may emerge as one possible response. This broader perspective helps explain why manufacturing location decision-making is

dynamic: what is continuously assessed is not reshoring itself, but the suitability of the location configuration over time.

During the awareness stage, reshoring considerations are often triggered by broad concerns such as supply chain disruptions, long lead times, declining delivery reliability, or geopolitical uncertainty. Paper IV shows that awareness stage in Nordic context is risk-led. These triggers raise attention but do not necessarily lead to decisions immediately. In the formal decision-making stage, firms engage in detailed evaluations, and this stage is value-led. Drivers, barriers, and enablers should all be included in consideration, including cost structures, capacity availability, and operational feasibility (Engström *et al.*, 2018a; Hilletofth *et al.*, 2021). This stage therefore reflects a more explicit comparison of whether reshoring, continued offshoring, or another alternative best supports firm's objective. At this stage, barriers and enablers become important, directly related to whether reshoring intentions can be translated into action.

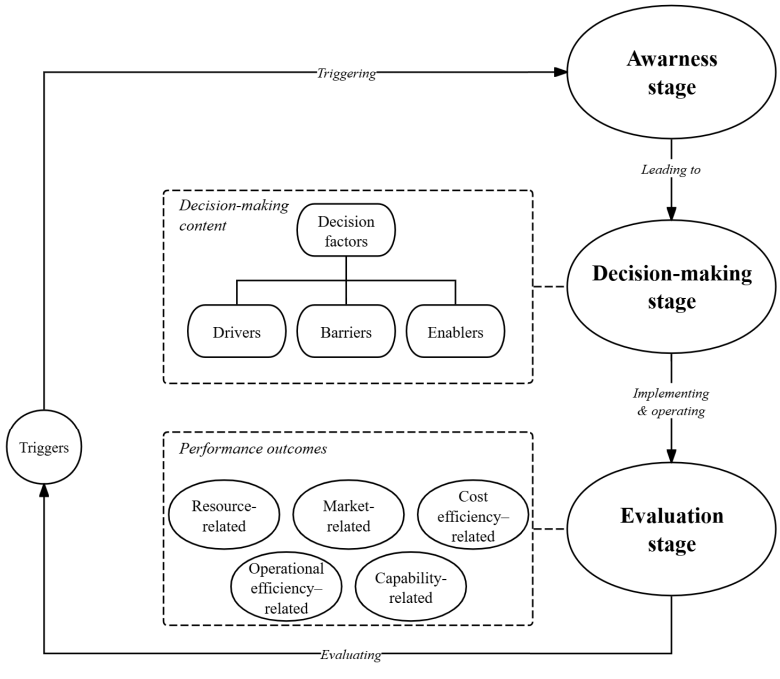


Figure 13 A process-based decision-making framework

As such, decisions do not end once a relocation choice is made. Figure 13 presented the loop of process-based decision-making framework. Findings also indicate the presence of an evaluation phase, where firms reassess their offshoring decisions to ensure alignment with evolving business strategies. This

helps explain observed loops, where firms are offshore, then reshore, or in some cases offshore again (i.e., second-degree relocation). However, after implementation and operations in the new location, decisions in the evaluation stage assess whether the realised outcomes of reshoring align with initial expectations and general strategic objectives. At this stage, firms do not re-evaluate decision factors, but performance outcomes. According to the EP, those strategic intentions can be translated to resource-related, cost efficiency-related, operational efficiency-related, market-related, and capacity-related outcomes. These cycles reflect ongoing adaptation, as an important view of the dynamic of manufacturing location decisions.

5.3.4 Temporal dynamics of reshoring decision-making content

The final dimension of dynamism identified concerns how reshoring decision-making content evolves over time in response to broader environmental changes. A comparison between earlier literature, recent literature and current empirical findings, and future expectations reveals temporal shifts. Paper IV captures expected future changes in relative priority rather than longitudinally observed changes in actual firm decisions.

Earlier literature emphasised more on cost-related and efficiency-driven factors, often framing reshoring as a corrective response to failed offshoring (Ellram *et al.*, 2013; Fratocchi *et al.*, 2016; Gray *et al.*, 2013). In contrast, the findings of this thesis show that contemporary reshoring decisions are also shaped by controllability, resilience, customer proximity, strategic flexibility, and operational performance. While efficiency-seeking factors are still dominant, broader operational performance and risk management related focus are witnessed.

Looking forward, experts in Paper IV anticipate a mixed future pattern across drivers and barriers. Interestingly, enablers display clearest future-oriented development. Enablers related to information access, technology, innovation, knowledge, strategic flexibility, resilience, and sustainability are expected to gain relative importance. Future reshoring will depend on both the possession of resources and firms' ability to combine and apply them effectively. Importantly, a lower future priority does not necessarily indicate it will become less important. Some factors may become baseline requirements, or be expected to become more manageable. Product quality, for example, may increasingly be regarded as a minimum condition rather than a driver that makes one location alternative attractive. The trend witnessed in enablers indicates broader movement from capacity attractiveness to capability readiness. These anticipated shifts strengthen the dynamic view of reshoring. Decision-making content will continue to evolve alongside changes in the global business and production environment.

6. Conclusions

This chapter summarises the main findings, outlines the theoretical contributions, discusses practical implications for industrial practitioners and policy-makers, and reflects on limitations and avenues for further research.

6.1 Main findings

This doctoral thesis sets out to advance understanding of manufacturing reshoring decision-making content in an era of deglobalisation, increased uncertainty, disruptions and strategic reconfiguration of the global business environment. By combining conceptual development with empirical studies, the thesis provides a theory-based explanation of reshoring dynamics. In particular, it explains which key factors are shaping reshoring decisions, how these factors interrelate and influence decisions, and how their influencing roles vary across contexts, and how their relative priorities differ across decision-making stages and over time.

Across five appended papers, this thesis demonstrates that manufacturing reshoring decision-making is multidimensional, interrelated, and dynamic, rather than a static evaluation. Table 16 summarises the main findings that answer each RQ.

Table 16 Summary of main findings by RQ

RQ	Main findings
RQ1: What are the key factors firms consider in manufacturing reshoring decision-making?	• Key factors can be organised according to four EP-based advantage-seeking categories. Some factors with hybrid-seeking characteristics reflect more than one category. • Efficiency-seeking factors (e.g. manufacturing cost, capacity, controllability, lead time, supply chain efficiency) dominate reshoring decision-making content. • Strategic asset-seeking factors (e.g. product quality, brand image, innovation capabilities, sustainability) have become increasingly important in contemporary reshoring decision-making. • Resource-seeking factors (e.g. labour resources, facilities and equipment, and production foundation) relate to production readiness and resource availability. • Market-seeking factors (e.g. customer service, customer proximity, patriotism, and service facilities) relate to market access, responsiveness, and customer value. • Hybrid-seeking factors show that some decision factors reflect multiple advantage-seeking logics simultaneously.

RQ	Main findings
RQ2: How do these key factors interrelate and influence manufacturing reshoring decisions?	• Decision factors do not influence reshoring decisions independently; they interact through trade-offs, complementarities, and contextual conditions. • One decision factor may serve as a driver, barrier, or enabler, depending on the context. • Enablers play a critical but often overlooked role in decision-making by supporting implementation readiness.
RQ3: How do shifts in decision-making content reflect the dynamic nature of manufacturing reshoring?	• Role dynamics show that the same decision factor may function as a driver, barrier, or enabler based on the context. • Advantage-seeking dynamics show the same decision factor may be interpreted through different advantage-seeking logics and may reflect several categories simultaneously. • Stage dynamics show that the same decision factor may be prioritised differently through decision-making stages, risk-led awareness and value-led formal assessment. • Temporal dynamics show that the same decision factor may be prioritised differently across time, future reshoring increasingly associated with broader capability readiness. • These shifts show that reshoring is part of an ongoing reassessment of manufacturing location configurations rather than a one-off decision.

The findings show that manufacturing reshoring decision-making content is structured, but factors within it should be understood with dynamic perspectives. Factors within it are interrelated and context-dependent; the influencing roles of one factor may change across decision-making stages and evolve over time. Its dynamic nature is also reflected in advantage-seeking interpretations. From a broader perspective, firms should assess reshoring in alignment with their broader competitive and manufacturing strategies. It should not be viewed as a one-off response to previous strategy. The analytical logic may also inform other manufacturing location decisions.

6.2 Theoretical contributions

This thesis makes several interrelated theoretical contributions to the literature on manufacturing reshoring and, more broadly, manufacturing location decision-making.

First, the thesis clarifies and advances the conceptual understanding of manufacturing reshoring decision-making content. Prior research on manufacturing has primarily focused on identifying drivers or motivations. This thesis explicitly theorises what constitutes the decision-making content itself by addressing what key factors firms evaluate, how these factors interrelate, and how they influence decision-making. Existing studies often present fragmented insights that are difficult to integrate across contexts. This thesis addresses this limitation by conceptualising decision-making content as a structured and multidimensional construct. Although developed through the study of reshoring, the

analytical logic may also inform research on other manufacturing relocation alternatives (e.g., offshoring, nearshoring). This contribution strengthens the theoretical foundation of location decision-making research by providing a clearer and more generalisable understanding of what firms evaluate when making manufacturing location decisions.

Second, the thesis advances conceptual clarity in reshoring decision-making content by distinguishing between decision factors and influencing factors and clarifies how these two types of factors interrelate. Existing research has largely focused on identifying factors labelled as drivers, barriers, or enablers (e.g., Engström *et al.*, 2018a; Johansson and Olhager, 2018b; Moradlou *et al.*, 2021), often without clearly defining their conceptual roles within decision-making content. These factors are frequently used interchangeably as criteria, conditions, requirements, or prerequisites, resulting in conceptual ambiguity and fragmented knowledge. This thesis addresses this limitation by introducing a clear analytical distinction. Decision factors refer to the factors firms evaluate when considering manufacturing location alternatives and represent the substantive content of decision-making. Influencing factors, in contrast, describe how decision factors function within a specific context. A decision factor becomes an influencing factor when it actively affects how, or to what extent, reshoring occurs. In this thesis, influencing factors are conceptualised through their roles as drivers, barriers, or enablers, which are contingent on country-, industry-, or firm-specific conditions, decision-making stages, and other contextual factors. The distinction and linkage between decision factors and influencing factors clarifies how the same factor can perform different roles across contexts and over time. This perspective introduces a more context-sensitive and process-oriented understanding of reshoring decisions. As such, the thesis enhances conceptual precision and provides a general analytical framework applicable to manufacturing location decision-making research more broadly.

Third, the thesis refines the application of the EP in manufacturing location decision research. Although the EP is widely cited in international business studies, its application in manufacturing relocation research has been limited and often narrowly interpreted, typically focusing only on location advantages or treating the framework as a static OLI parameter classification. By tracing the development and limitations of the EP and systematically reviewing its application in manufacturing location studies, this thesis clarifies its conceptual foundations and analytical logic in the context of manufacturing location decisions. The thesis demonstrates how advantage-seeking logics interact with OLI parameters and introduces the Strategic Positioning Matrix, which enables scholars to identify firm roles within manufacturing location decisions. Through the development of this matrix, the thesis provides a conceptual tool that integrates OLI parameters, advantage-seeking logics, and firm roles. This

enhances the explanatory power of the EP and provides a structured approach for analysing manufacturing location decisions across different strategic contexts. By strengthening the internal coherence and explanatory capability of an established theoretical framework, this contribution provides clearer guidance for its consistent application and encourages its broader use in manufacturing location research.

Finally, the thesis conceptualises the dynamic nature of manufacturing reshoring decision-making content through four complementary dimensions: role dynamics, advantage-seeking dynamics, stage dynamics, and temporal dynamics. These dimensions extend reshoring research beyond static representations of decision factors, show how their roles, strategic interpretations, and relative priorities vary across contexts, decision-making stages, and time.

This conceptualisation links decision-making content to the ongoing reconfiguration of manufacturing locations. It helps explain why location decisions may be repeatedly reassessed as conditions change. It therefore provides a more realistic and theoretically grounded understanding. The dynamic perspective can also be used to understand beyond reshoring.

6.3 Practical implications

This thesis also carries important managerial implications for industrial practice and policy development. This thesis shows that manufacturing reshoring decision-making content is structured, multidimensional, and evolving. The roles and relative priorities of decision factors may vary across contexts, decision-making stages, and time horizons. For practitioners, this means that reshoring decisions should be based on a systematic and analytically grounded evaluation of decision factors and influencing factors. This perspective enables managers to navigate their manufacturing strategy in volatile global environments.

First, the thesis demonstrates that reshoring decisions should not be based solely on a single perspective, such as financial comparisons. Such an approach may overlook hidden costs and operational consequences, potentially leading to implementation failures. Reshoring should also not be viewed as a short-term reaction to external disruptions. Such decisions involve a complex configuration of interrelated factors. To make informed decisions, managers need to recognise that factors' relevance and roles may shift across contexts and over time. This implies that manufacturing reshoring decisions require systematic and structured evaluation. The distinction and linkage between decision factors and influencing factors clarify the structure of decision-making content. By understanding how one factor may function as a driver, barrier, or enabler, firms can improve the transparency of strategic reasoning in internal decision-making.

Second, the thesis highlights the dynamic nature of reshoring decision-making content. Reshoring decision-making unfolds across stages and has temporal characteristics. It is important to distinguish risk-led awareness and value-led formal assessment. Awareness-related triggers usually related to external risks, such as supply chain disruptions or rising costs, may initiate awareness, but they do not necessarily determine the final decision. The importance of factors may shift in the formal decision-making and subsequent reassessments. During formal assessment, managers need to evaluate a broader combination of resource-seeking, efficiency-seeking, market-seeking, and strategic asset-seeking considerations. Managers should distinguish between factors that trigger reconsideration and criteria used to assess location alternatives. These continuous reassessments are equally important as the initial evaluation. Practitioners should therefore not treat reshoring as a one-off optimisation solution. Incorporating evaluation loops can help firms ensure alignment between manufacturing strategy and general business strategy under evolving conditions.

Third, the development of the Strategic Positioning Matrix (Paper V) provides managers with a structured lens for aligning reshoring initiatives with their broader strategic objectives. Managers may ask whether a relocation initiative is primarily driven by resource-seeking, efficiency-seeking, market-seeking, or strategic asset-seeking logics. By reflecting on this question, with the matrix, firms can better assess the coherence between strategic intent and organisational capabilities. This highlights the need for trade-offs among different advantage-seeking logics. The conceptual tool can help firms position their roles (builders, seekers, absorbers) according to their general strategies and capacities. For practitioners who want to make well-informed decisions, the matrix can support clearer strategic positioning, better identification of advantages and constraints, and sufficient preparation for implementation.

Fourth, prior research has given comparatively limited attention to the enablers of reshoring. This thesis encourages managers to explicitly assess organisational readiness (enablers) before initiating reshoring. This includes evaluating the availability of manufacturing capacity, the adequacy of competencies and know-hows, the level of automation. These often determine whether reshoring ideas can be translated into feasible actions. Managers who explicitly assess these internal prerequisites at an early stage are more likely to succeed. Post-implementation evaluation is essential, as business environments are consistently changing, which may affect the strategic fit of a chosen production configuration over time. Reshoring may also require organisational adjustments beyond the physical relocation of manufacturing activities.

For policymakers, the thesis suggests that effective policy support for reshoring is essential. Policies that strengthen industrial capabilities, such as investments in labour skills development, infrastructure, innovation, and

automation, can improve the structural competitiveness of the domestic manufacturing environment and facilitate reshoring initiatives. This understanding can help policymakers influence how firms interpret and prioritise decision factors when reassessing manufacturing location configurations.

6.4 Limitations and further research

Every study has its own limitations, and the limitations open avenues for future research. First, *Study B* and *Study C* focused primarily on Nordic manufacturing contexts, and all participants' headquarters are located in Sweden. The Nordic manufacturing contexts are characterised by strong industrial bases, advanced technologies, high levels of automation, advanced capabilities, and high labour costs. The findings may not be directly transferable to regions with different conditions. However, this study provides analytical insights into reshoring decision-making content, those factors may not only applicable for reshoring, but they are also transferable to various location decision contexts with similar conditions. Future studies could apply the decision-making framework to other regions and other location alternatives.

Second, although this thesis identifies a comprehensive set of decision factors, *Study C* quantitatively compares their relative priorities across contexts using a limited expert sample. The resulting indices should be interpreted as structured expert assessments. Future studies could use larger and more representative samples to validate these patterns and provide more generalisable estimates of factors' relative importance. In addition, the thesis does not explicitly distinguish between different industries. Future research could incorporate industry as an analytical variable to further research about the reshoring dynamics. If extend this work through larger-scale surveys or longitudinal studies, further research can test the relative strength of different factors, examine how they influence one another.

Third, this thesis recognises that some factors become important in the awareness stage and may trigger reassessment of existing manufacturing location configurations. These factors can be called triggers. However, this thesis does not develop a detailed conceptual distinction between triggers and drivers. Drivers in this thesis are treated as motivations or triggers for initiating reshoring; however, some research suggests they should be investigated separately (Bettiol *et al.*, 2023). Future studies could separate these concepts and explore how different types of triggers initiate reshoring awareness.

Finally, future research could further examine the performance outcomes of reshoring by linking decision-making drivers, barriers, and enablers to short-term and long-term outcomes. This would help explain how realised outcomes become inputs into later manufacturing location reassessment cycles.

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Appendix

Appendix 1 Interview guide for *Study B*

Questions related to the reshoring project

1. What was the reshoring project about?
2. Who was involved?
3. Where did it take place?
4. When did it take place?
5. Why did it take place?
6. How did it take place?

Questions related to the reshoring decision-making process

7. What were the overall stages and activities in your reshoring project?

Questions related to the reshoring decision-making content

8. What were the decision criteria considered in your reshoring project?
9. What were the barriers, drivers, and enablers in your reshoring project?

Questions related to the reshoring assessment

10. How did you conduct the risk and cost assessment in your reshoring project?

Questions related to the reshoring outcomes

11. What were the outcomes of your reshoring project?

Appendix 2 Interview guide for *Study C*

A. **Scholar Perspective Survey**

Part A. General background

1. How many years of research experience do you have in the manufacturing field?
    - o 0–5
    - o 6–10
    - o 11–15
    - o 16–20
    - o More than 20
2. How many manufacturing relocation projects have you investigated?
    - o 0–5
    - o 6–10
    - o 11–15
    - o 16–20
    - o More than 20
3. To your knowledge, how frequently do companies consider relocation?
    - o Never
    - o Very rarely, ≤ once every 10 years
    - o Rarely, once every 5–10 years
    - o Occasionally, once every 2–5 years
    - o Sometimes, once every 1–2 years
    - o Annually

Part B. Reshoring decision-making content

4. To what extent do most companies align with the following reshoring strategies?
    - o Resource-seeking: to access resources that are exclusive, more accessible, or of superior quality
    - o Market-seeking: to exploit market opportunities
    - o Efficiency-seeking: to explore cost-efficient and productivity-enhancing manufacturing
    - o Strategic asset-seeking: to access strategic or knowledge-related assets

    Response scale:
    - o Not at all
    - o Small extent
    - o Moderate extent
    - o Large extent
    - o Very large extent
    - o N/A

5. Decision factors can motivate, impede, or facilitate reshoring. Based on your knowledge or experience, please indicate how each factor influences the decision and to what extent.

   Each factor could be assessed as:
   - Driver: minor, moderate, or major importance
   - Barrier: minor, moderate, or major importance
   - Enabler: minor, moderate, or major importance

6. Please select the factors that are most likely to be important drivers, barriers, or enablers for future reshoring decisions, within the next 1–5 years.

7. Please select the key factors that are important at the awareness stage of reshoring, before formal decision-making.

B. **Industrial Perspective Survey**

Part A. General background

1. How many years of working experience do you have in the manufacturing industry?
   - 0–5
   - 6–10
   - 11–15
   - 16–20
   - More than 20

2. Please identify your company's industry sector.

3. How many years have you worked for this company?
   - 0–5
   - 6–10
   - 11–15
   - 16–20
   - More than 20

4. How many employees does your company currently have?
   - 1–9
   - 10–250
   - 251–500
   - 501–1,000
   - 1,001–2,000
   - More than 2,000

5. What kinds of manufacturing relocation projects has your company completed, is currently working on, or is planning, either from your company's plant or from an external supplier?

   Project types: Offshoring/Reshoring

Status options: Completed/Working on/Planning

6. To your knowledge, how frequently has your organisation considered relocation?
    - Never
    - Very rarely, ≤ once every 10 years
    - Rarely, once every 5–10 years
    - Occasionally, once every 2–5 years
    - Sometimes, once every 1–2 years
    - Annually

Part B. Reshoring decision-making content

7. To what extent is your company aligned with the following relocation strategies?

    - Resource-seeking: to access resources that are exclusive, more accessible, or of superior quality
    - Market-seeking: to exploit market opportunities
    - Efficiency-seeking: to explore cost-efficient and productivity-enhancing manufacturing
    - Strategic asset-seeking: to access strategic or knowledge-related assets

    Response scale:
    - Not at all
    - Small extent
    - Moderate extent
    - Large extent
    - Very large extent
    - N/A

8. Decision factors can motivate, impede, or facilitate reshoring. Based on your reshoring experience, please indicate how each factor has influenced the decision and to what extent.

    Each factor could be assessed as:
    - Driver: minor, moderate, or major importance
    - Barrier: minor, moderate, or major importance
    - Enabler: minor, moderate, or major importance

9. Please select the factors that are most likely to be important drivers, barriers, or enablers for future reshoring decisions, within the next 1–5 years.

10. Please select the key factors that are important at the awareness stage of reshoring, before formal decision-making.

C. **Decision Factors Included in the Survey**

The following decision factors were included across the *Study C* survey instrument:

EP	Decision factors
Resource-seeking	Business partners; currency exchange rate; facilities & equipment; labour resources; natural resources; production foundation
Market-seeking	Customer proximity; customer service; patriotism; raw material access & cost; service facilities
Efficiency-seeking	Controllability of production; coordination cost; delivery lead time; energy cost; external communication; function synchronisation; geographical and cultural distance; global economic conditions; information technology; information transfer; inventory level and cost;
	labour cost; labour market flexibility; labour productivity; logistics cost; logistics performance; macroeconomics; manufacturing capacity; manufacturing cost; manufacturing risks; natural disasters; overhead cost; political stability; production flexibility; replenishment lead time;
	social and ethical concerns; societal disruptions; strategic flexibility; subsidies; supply chain agility; supply chain flexibility; supply chain resilience; supply chain risks; supply chain visibility; time to market; total cost; trade and payment terms
Strategic asset-seeking	Brand image & reputation; competitive pressure; competitive priorities; core competencies; countertrade requirements; innovation ability; knowledge transfer; ownership-related issues; product quality; production & process quality; servitisation strategy; strategy shift; tax advantages
Hybrid-seeking	Customer demand; customisation strategy; government incentives; industrial agglomeration; information access; infrastructure; know-how & IP; knowledge & technology; legislation & regulations; made-in effect; management performance; manufacturing automation level; market opportunities; R&D; responsible supply chain; responsiveness to market; supply networks; sustainable supply chain; technology agglomeration

Source: Adapted from Li *et al.* (2025b).

Papers
Associated papers have been removed in the electronic version of this thesis.
For more details about the papers see:
https://urn.kb.se/resolve?urn=urn:nbn:se:hig:diva-49513